Knight Avant!

Renee Greene



DeBokton Book

Find your hero within!

DeBokton.com

Copyright © 2024 by Renee Greene

DeBokton Book

All rights reserved. No part of this book may be reproduced or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or mechanical, including photocopying, recording, or by any information storage and retrieval system, without written permission from the publisher or author.

ISBN: 9798320194585

Dedicated to:

Tom MacDonald and Nova Rockafeller

who were the inspiration for the hero and heroine of this adventure.

Tom and Nova,

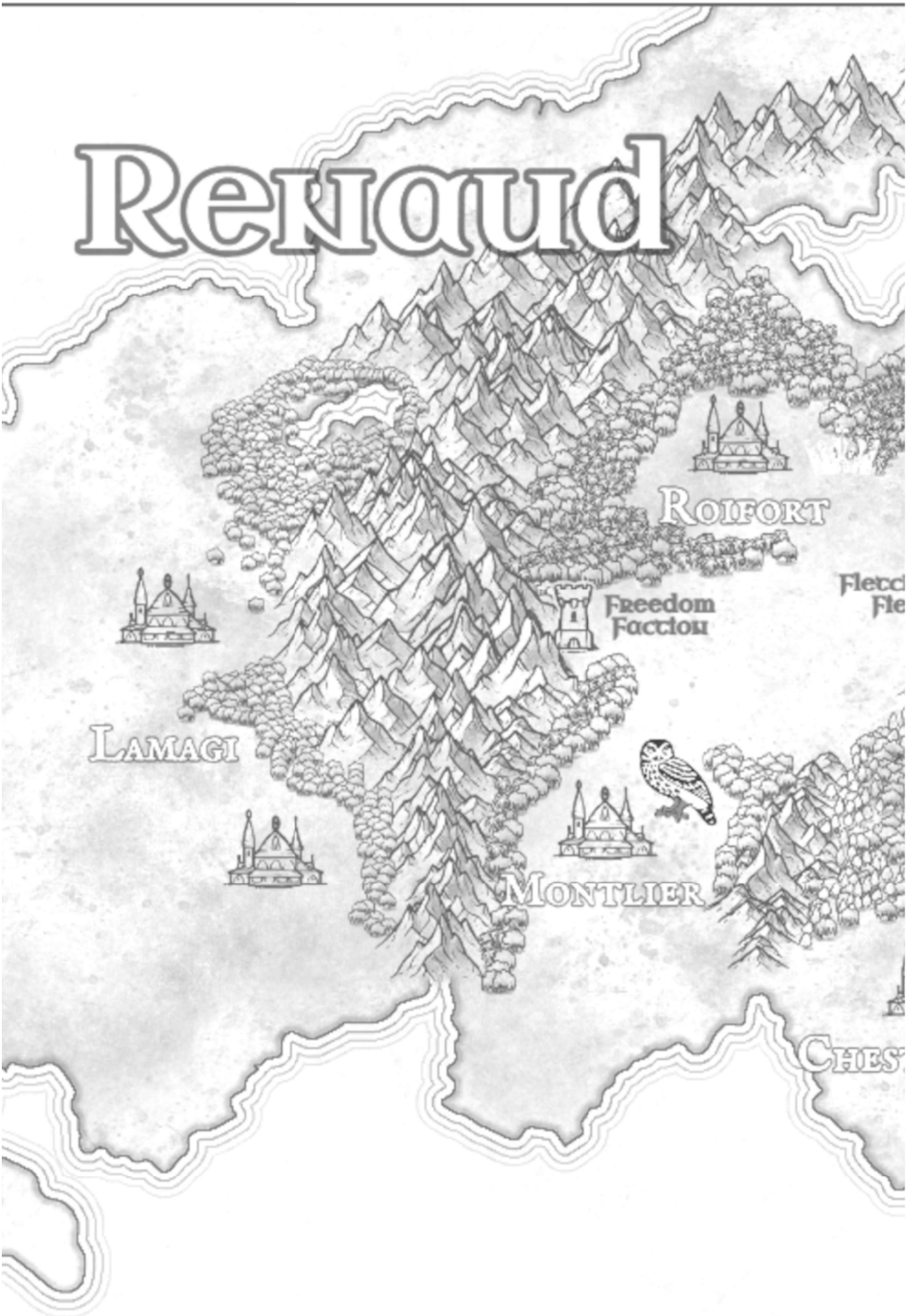
Please accept this as a gift from a fan. I hope you read it and enjoy it. I'd love to hear what you think of it. I write obsessively as a hobby, and really thought the two of you would make great heroes in a fantasy novel, as you are so heroic and inspiring in real life.

I hope I bring some joy to you and puts a smile on your faces. The two of you have helped me through some hard times, and I've learned I need to build my castle from the sticks and the stones.

I am, as a typical author, editing, so I have the edited chapters here. For the rest, please email me at darkhairedhalfling@yahoo.com.

Happy reading!

-- Renee Greene


Renaud
Roifort
Freedom
Faction
Lamagi
Montlier


Arwood
Varoux
Fletcher's Field
Tamur
Bellemar
Chesterfield
N
W
E
S

Table of Contents

Chapter 1: Fists, Fights, and a Really Dangerous Bet.....9

Chapter 2: Fire, Flips, and a Serious Threat.....23

Chapter 3: Ale, Songs, and One Hard Punch.....29

Chapter 4: A Challenge, Disappointment, and a Hangover ..... .45

Chapter 5: A Story, A Brawl, and a Pretty Dance Partner ..... .53

Chapter 6: Market, The Great Hall, and an Offer that Couldn't Be Refused.....69

Chapter 7: Beasts, Blood, and a Cute Little Girl.....79

Chapter 8: A Fish, a Backdoor, and a Really Inaccurate Tale.....88

Chapter 9: A Meeting, a Secret Plot, and Cooked Herring ..... .99

Chapter 10: Another fight, a Truthful Song, and a Round of Ale.....108

Chapter 11: Captives, Fire, and an *Intimidating* Duke. 119

Chapter 12: A *Gati, A Sprite, and A Beautiful Faunen*. 130

Chapter 13: Misery, Mistakes, and a Spiked Whip.....140

Chapter 14: Recovery, a Goal, and a Suitor.....151

Chapter 15: A Song, an Argument, and a Spicy Lime. .159

Chapter 16: A Raid, A New Guild, and A Lifeless Halo ..... .166

Chapter 17: A Song, a Hint, and a Big Coincidence.....172

Chapter 18: A Legend, History, and a Mock Sword Fight ..... .178
Chapter 19: Good News, A Mother, and a Meeting with a Lord.....189
Chapter 20: A Chimera, An Exposing Song, and An Unwanted Order.....194
Chapter 21: A Deal, A Beating, and a Long Shot.....206
Chapter 22: A Secret Meeting, an Open Meeting, and a Demotion..... .213
Chapter 23: Singing, Dancing, and Big Threats.....225
Chapter 24: A King, A Threat, and a Wishy-Washy Verdict.....233
Chapter 25: A Beast, A Faunen, and a Rhyme War……244
Chapter 26: A Trap, Mercenaries, and a Lord's Guards256
Chapter 27: A Really Bad Song, A Game, and A Spy...264
Chapter 28: The Mine, A Secret Passage, and Glowing Green Moss.....278
Chapter 29: Boar Meat, a Sassy Girl, and an Unfinished Tale.....290
Chapter 30: Sunlight, A Story of Corruption, and An Unexpected Kiss..... .299
Chapter 31: A Dungeon Break, Mutton Sandwiches, and a Proud Woman.....312
Chapter 32: A Morose Song, A Panicked Faunen, and an Unsuccessful Lie.....322
Chapter 33: Lies, More Lies, and a Challenge to the Death.....331
Chapter 34: A Bloody Battle, Tied Prisoners, and a Bunny Guard..... .344

Chapter 35: A Coward, A Winner, and a Magic Trick. .352
Chapter 36: Demands, Whining, and a Killer Raccoon367
Chapter 37: A Medal of Honor, An Insult, and a Juggling War.....374

Chapter 1: Fists, Fights, and a Really Dangerous Bet

Allistair clasped his hands nervously as he watched the gruesome fight on the field the crowd was gathered around, knowing he would be next.

His best friend, Hartley, a lanky man with pointy Elven ears and a monkey tail that was flicking a restless rhythm against the wooden barrier he was leaning against, slapped his hand on Allistair's shoulder and encouraged, "Don't worry. If you win this, you walk out with a fat purse. If not, you'll likely be dead, so you won't feel a thing."

"Feckin' brilliant," Allistair quipped. "Remind me again why I keep you around."

"Because I'm the only one who tells you the truth to keep your head on straight," Hartley grinned, flicking his tail. "I'm just trying to lessen the nerves. You can beat

either of these men. You have a massive size advantage over the cat-boy, and the giant is huge, but the bigger they are, the harder they fall."

Allistair wished he shared Hartley's confidence. He looked out at the men fighting. An eight-foot tall giant, named Theo, grabbed at a man two-and-a-half feet shorter than him with cat ears on the top of his head and a tail. The cat-man, from a race called the Crevan – a breed where everyone carried at least one animal trait – was quick, ducked out of the way, and struck with his sharp claws. As he did, he dropped to the ground and swept Theo's leg, hoping the giant would fall.

The crowd cheered, but Allistair tensed, seeing the mistake the crevan had made.

Theo fell with a giant thud, but as he did, he was able to turn, fall beside the crevan, and elbow him in the face, knocking him out cold and sending more blood spattered on the ground.

Gasps from the crowd rose, as the crevan was obviously injured, and Allistair could feel his heart beating in his chest. He'd have to fight Theo next, and he could end up as broken as the crevan. Allistair stared at Theo, who was roaring to the crowd with his fists pumped high in the air. Theo was terrifying, a mountain of muscle, with a jaw like an anvil, and a manner more beast than man.

A heraldic trumpet sounded victory for Theo. Some in the crowd, mostly filled with commoners watching from the stands, cheered wildly for him, while others booed, hoping to see the underdog win. Allistair wished the crevan had won. Fighting the giant would be hard. He'd rather have fought the crevan. Crevan often had

hyper-senses due to their animal, so that gave them very quick reflexes, but Allistair would rather fight that than Theo, the most colossal giant Allistair had ever laid eyes on.

Everyone in the stands had favorites, as they watched tournaments often. After all, tourney games were allowed in all cities in the kingdom of Renaud and were a favorite pastime in the town of Chesterfield.

Chesterfield was a striking coastal town, encompassed by rolling meadows, dense woods, and a sweeping view of the mountains in the distance. From high in a tree, the distant battlements of Roifort could be seen. Roifort, the capital city where the king held court, towered majestically above the surrounding lands.

The beautiful scenery and the cool breeze didn't really matter to most of the people at the tourney that day. They cared about the brutal competitions at hand.

The crowd was all excited as, after a short break for the champion to rest, the herald announced the final match of the day. The normal townfolks and tourney champions weren't allowed to do jousting, as that was a knight's event, so they had sword fighting with wooden swords, where the fighters fought until one surrendered, staff fighting, which was done on several logs with the object being to knock the opponent off. The biggest event was the wrestling matches. There were few rules, so really it was more grappling than wrestling. Many people called it that.

The herald announced, "Attention, everyone! This is the big event everyone has been waiting for! Our final two competitors are Theo, the giant, verses Allistair, the Mokos." He was going to say more, but the crowd went

wild, their screams of excitement ringing through the air, so his voice could not be heard.

Theo the giant came out first, roaring to the crowd and pumping his fists, urging on the grand chorus of cheers that rang out for him. That wasn't encouraging to Allistair. Those same people would be rooting for him to lose, possibly die.

Next it was Allistair's turn. He waited nervously at the side as Theo went out, bouncing around a bit to pump himself up with energy. When it was time, he ran out, raised his hands high, and called out, "Make some noise! I'm fighting this for you!"

The crowd gave an eager "huzzah" and cheered as if he'd just defeated a bull, as he stepped over and faced off with Theo.

Allistair was not short, as he was part-giant himself and stood a little over six feet tall, but still, he had to lean his head back to look up at Theo. The eight-foot-tall opponent was as intimidating as facing a massive beast. Theo obviously was full giant, which was rare. Allistair's main race was that of mokos. The mokos had the trait that their skin was marked with markings they earned. Allistair had a marking on his right forearm, a rampant centaur carrying a torch. That was fitting, as the centaur represented passion, and the rampant position showed he was passionate about his fighting. The torch represented zeal for life, truth, and intelligence.

Hopefully his energy and passion would help him defeat an opponent so much larger and fiercer than he was.

Theo glared down at him and taunted, "Prepare to die!"

“Please, don’t kill me,” Allistair pleaded. “I am rather fond of being alive.”

To his surprise, Theo kept his hard expression, but responded, “I won’t, but I will put on a good show, and I will win, which I warn you may hurt.” He then called to the crowd, “Watch me kick him to Roifort!” and gestured with his hands to encourage them to cheer. They did, very vociferously.

Allistair stared at Theo in utter shock. Was Theo not really as out for blood as he appeared? Was there a side to Theo that he didn’t show to the public? Apparently, to Theo the contest was more show than fight, perhaps because Theo never lost. Allistair took a breath, trying to focus. Hopefully, he could make Theo see what it felt like to lose.

Allistair held his fist up to the crowd, and received mighty cheers to, but were they for him or due to the crowd wanting to see a good opponent for Theo to crush?

Allistair breathed deeply. The fight wasn’t to the death, but it would likely be to knock-out. Concession was allowed, but not respected, so there was no way Allistair would humiliate himself and concede.

“I’m going to break you,” Theo threatened, but Allistair ignored him, hoping Theo was trying to intimidate him and put on a show for the crowd.

Instead of throwing a taunt back, Allistair jumped around a bit for show as he punched the air. That time the crowd roared as if he’d just fought a lion. It was good to have the support of the fans, but they had much greater faith in him than he did himself. Theo was going to be a tough opponent, like a rogue warhorse who trampled his own master, so Allistair would likely leave in pain.

At the sound of a horn, he suddenly stopped dancing around and took his stance to start. He could feel his heart beating. He needed to win. The prize for winning wasn't huge, but winning tournaments put food on the table, and he didn't want to let the people down either.

The herald then unleashed a piercing blast of his trumpet to signal the start of the fight.

Theo lunged forward, trying to jump on Allistair and crush him beneath his massive weight, but where Theo had the size and strength advantage, Allistair had the dexterity advantage. He hit the blood spattered ground, rolled cleanly out of the way and back up to his feet. As soon as he stood up, he kicked viciously at Theo. Theo grabbed his foot and threw him, hoping to shatter him against the ground, but Allistair flew back and did a flawless back tuck, landing solidly on his feet.

Theo tried to pound Allistair with both fists, but Allistair turned straight into him, grabbed both wrists, and used his lower center of gravity to throw Theo to the ground.

Theo fell with a bone-rattling thud, and Allistair jumped on top of him. Unfortunately, Theo surged forward, rolling over on top of him and viciously pounding on him with his massive knuckles. Each punch felt like getting hit with a sledgehammer, and Allistair feared his head would crack open. The headache alone made him feel as if his skull would split from the raw agony. Why the feck was he having to fight a giant? Fighting crevan, other mokos, or even rhys would have been better, and rhys were dragon people who could create fire in their hands.

Allistair jammed the heel of his hand directly into

Theo's chin, pushing back with every ounce of leverage he could muster until Theo was forced to move back, giving Allistair just enough room to roll out from under him.

Allistair's head was spinning, but he had to focus. He jumped up and came down hard on Theo, driving his elbow into the giant's back. Theo let out an audible "oof" and tried to knock Allistair off his back, but Allistair grabbed his arm and pulled it back into a brutal lock.

"Give up," Allistair urged, his voice a tight snarl. "I could break your arm."

Theo didn't submit, but leveraged his massive bulk to roll over and break free.

As the giant started to sit up. Allistair slammed a foot on his shoulder and quickly flipped back, surprising Theo by landing squarely on his chest and knocking him down again. Allistair then pulled his fist back and unleashed a finishing blow that knocked Theo instantly unconscious.

The crowd went wild, and Allistair raised his fists in victory. Then he put his foot on Theo and posed, forcing his muscles to lock so the searing pain wouldn't show. The roar of the excited crowd always gave him such a surge of excitement that he could work the crowd despite the pain of the bruises and the blood running down his face. With all the excitement and the dizziness, he hadn't even noticed that Theo had severely cut his ear.

The herald blew the horn again, so the crowd stopped cheering, and Allistair stepped up to receive the award.

The tournaments in Chesterfield didn't have huge prizes, as they were local, small-scale events hosted by a mere lord, Lord Urvan. He lacked the fortunes of the

dukes who rule the big cities, let alone the bottomless wealth of the king. Tournaments in the capital city of Roifort definitely paid better.

Still, Allistair was handed a leather pouch containing twenty copper coins by a strikingly beautiful maiden whose face was instantly recognizable. Everyone in the province knew who she was – Lina, the captivating minstrel. Her main race was that of a sprite. Sprites looked fairly normal, except that they could change their coloring at will. That day, she had long, yellow hair with pink tips that showed off her bright icy blue eyes. Sprites excelled at any sort of art. Lina's voice could put a nightingale to shame. She performed as a minstrel often, and everyone knew and loved her, as her bubbly personality always seemed to brighten everyone's day. Lord Urvan liked to have her help with the tournaments as people would join the crowd just to see her and hear her perform during breaks.

"You didn't die out there – well done," she complimented, her eyes dancing with mischief as she handed Allistair the pouch. She then chuckled and teased, "Honestly, you looked half-decent. Good thing for you I wasn't a contestant today, or you would have been the one eating dirt."

"Right," Allistair chuckled. "You weigh what, a hundred pounds soaking wet? Come on."

"I'd still beat you," she teased back. "You're way too much of a gentleman to actually hit a girl."

Allistair shook his head and chuckled as he conceded, "All right. Fair enough. You have me there." Then he winked and whispered, "I wouldn't knock you out, but it wouldn't take much to scoop you up, set you

gently on the ground, and sit on you so you couldn't get up and have to concede."

"You keep thinking that. I'm full of surprises," she teased back. "Are you ticklish?"

She winked at him, took his hand, raised it to the crowd, and called out, "Clap unless you think you can beat him!" The crowd laughed at her comment, and once again cheered for Allistair. He basked in the glory, the prize, the beautiful girl, and the approval of the crowd making the pain worth it.

The cheers stopped, instantly silent, as a man with a commanding presence walked out on the field, Sir Elliot. He was a lesser knight serving as an ambassador from Roifort to Chesterfield, thought his primary duty was to collect taxes for the king. He was part crevan and part rhys. Sometimes rhys were referred to as dragon people. They didn't genuinely resemble dragons, but they were given the name because they had horns on their heads and could produce fire from their hands. They couldn't control the fire or throw fireballs, but they could catch a haystack on fire or burn an enemy with a touch, a truly intimidating ability. Sir Elliot had ram horns instead of the normal rhys horns, as his crevan animal was a ram. He did have the rhys ability of lighting his hands on fire, but lacked the common rhys trait of having a tail. His look was as terrifying as an executioner, and his temperament as merciless as the headsman's axe.

No one cheered as Sir Elliot took the field, the crowd paralyzed, knowing his appearance there meant something grim was about to happen.

He marched directly up to Allistair and Lina and hissed, "Move aside. It's my turn."

Allistair stepped in front of Lina to protect her and, without a trace of fear, quipped back, “Did you know your nose is crooked? Hold still a second, I think I can punch it back in place.”

“Don’t threaten me, lad!” Elliot seethed.

“It was just an offer,” Allistair replied, sounding as casual as if Elliot had just offered him some mead. He then suggested to Lina, “Let’s go.”

Before Lina walked off, she peeked around Allistair and quipped to Elliot, “Your nose is crooked. I guess it matches the rest of you.” She then smiled at him, nodded, and walked off with Allistair.

Sir Elliot threw his nose in the air, turned away from them, and addressed the crowd. “Lords, Ladies, and peasants, I, Sir Elliot, ambassador from the king, have been instructed by King Didier to announce that there will be a small increase in taxes, just a trifle.”

The crowd began to boo, but Sir Elliot put his hand on his sword, and hissed, “You will obey me as you do the king. I speak in his name!”

Silence instantly fell on the crowd, cold silence that send shivers of fear through everyone. Elliot was feared, known not just for his ruthless demeanor, but for his skill with a sword, and his willingness to make an example of anyone who crossed him. He also could call for help from the knights of the noble houses, who were known for backing the local knights, no matter what mischief they were involved in. The only group of knights the people really had faith left in was the Knight Avants, a special force directly under the king’s command. Their reputation described them as noble, brave, and defenders of the people. One day, Allistair hoped to join them.

Not even a breath could be heard from the crowd as Sir Elliot continued in a sugary tone, “Peasants, know that King Didier cares about you. I do too. We do not delight in seeing peasants suffer, but the tax is necessary. Our kingdom is at threat of war. The kingdoms across the mountains are building armies. There are other needs too, and every citizen must do his part to help the kingdom as a whole. So in one week, the town of Chesterfield will pay an additional tax of five-hundred silver pieces.”

A wave of horrified gasps broke the silence of the crowd. Five hundred silver pieces was a king’s ransom. The town of Chesterfield only had about two thousand people in it total, so that amounted to about a quarter of a silver piece for each person. Large families would be hit hard, as a silver piece was worth ten coppers, and two coppers was considered a fair day’s wage.

The excitement of the fights was suddenly dampened, a fog of despair sticking to everyone.

Allistair stepped right into Elliot’s space, squaring his shoulders. “Tell you what – let’s make a deal? You and me, right here, right now, a straight grapple. If I win, you scrap the extortion. We pay nothing. If you win, we toss in ten extra silver pieces.”

Elliot waved his gauntleted hand flippantly. “I have my orders. The tax is five hundred silver.”

“What, you scared?” Allistair mocked, a sharp, cynical grin cutting across his face. “Afraid that without your fancy sword and your little knights backing you up that you can’t actually beat me in a fair fight?”

Elliot glared at him, his jaw tightening. “I’m not afraid of you. I am a knight. I could crush you easily.”

“Then prove it. Step up and take the challenge,”

Allistair barked. He spun around to face the crowd, throwing his arms wide as he called out, “What do you say? Do you want to see this big bad knight grapple with me?”

The crowd began cheering wildly until it broke out chanting, “Fight! Fight! Fight!”

“Double the tax if I win,” Elliot countered.

“That’s highway robbery, and we both know it,” Allistair shot back, shaking his head. “Twenty extra silver pieces if I lose. Take it or leave it.”

“Fifty,” Elliot hissed. “But if I lose, the tax is only cut in half.”

Allistair turned to the crowd, spreading his arms wide and projecting his voice over the noise. “Listen up! This cur, the crown’s favorite lapdog, wants fifty extra silver out of your pockets if I go down, but will only cut his rotten tax by half if I win. Are we taking these rigged odd or what?”

That was an obvious choice for the crowd. They again chanted, “Fight! Fight! Fight!”

“Deal,” Allistair agreed with a confident smile. “Step into the dirt.”

“One more condition,” Elliot corrected. “I get to use my sword.”

Allistair’s heart began racing, pounding as if trying to escape his chest,, and he could feel the palms of his hands sweating. “The challenge was a straight grapple, coward,” he snapped.

“If you want the chance at two-hundred and fifty for the tax, you have to meet my conditions,” Elliot sneered.

He stepped closer, hissing in Allistair's face, "Are you afraid?"

Was he afraid? Of course he was afraid. He'd be a feckin' fool not to be afraid. Yet, he met Elliot's glare without flinching. "If I win, the tax lowers to two-hundred."

Elliot laughed a mocking laugh. "If you win? This is a death wish for you. I have fire, horns, and a sword. You cannot beat me."

"Quit stalling, two hundred?" Allistair pressed.

Elliot chuckled. "Two-hundred silver, but not a copper less."

Allistair turned to the crowd. He clasped his hands together for a moment to keep them from shaking, hiding the tremor behind a showman's bravado. Then he took a breath, raised his hand to the crowd, and called out, "He wants to bring steel to a wrestling match! Two-hundred silver if I beat a man with fire, horns, and a blade. Do we do it?"

"Huzzah!" the crowd cheered.

"I'm unarmed. I could actually die!" Allistair called back, half-hoping the people would come to their senses.

"Huzzah!" the crowd cheered again. "Do it!" Once again the erupted into chanting, "Fight! Fight! Fight!"

Allistair smiled back at the crowd, forcing a grin across his face so they wouldn't see how much it hurt to have them calling for his likely death. Sure, it would save them money, and they really didn't understand how brutal fights really were, not every having felt the bite of steel or the pounding of fists. To them, blood on the field was just cheap entertainment. Still, he'd hoped he was worth

more than three hundred silver pieces to the people he was trying to protect.

He sighed, shaking his head at their blind, reckless expectation. They had way too much faith in him.

He turned his back on the cheering stands, rolling his shoulders as Elliot's sword cleared its scabbard with a sharp, metallic hiss.

Allistair raised his empty, calloused, bare knuckles, knowing he was about to bleed for a crowd that loved his name, yet still valued silver more than his life.

Chapter 2: Fire, Flips, and a Serious Threat

Allistair started to turn to take his place in the dirt, trying to relax his muscles for the fight, when a sudden blur approached, stopping in front of him to reveal it was Lina. She shoved a battered flask straight against his chest.

“Drink up, big guy!” she offered as she handed it to him, her eyes wide, bright, and filled with energy. “You just fought a mountain, and now you are going to dance with a fire-breathing snake. You must be parched. Chug it before you drop.”

Allistair thanked her, took the flask, and guzzled the yeasty table ale, surprised by the sharp, cooling bite of peppermint infused into the brew. As he drank, Lina rattled on, “You can win this if you fight smart. Don’t let this crooked-nose knave get inside your head. He’s wandought, incredibly weak. Sure, he has steal and fire, but a sword only does much good if he doesn’t know how to use it.”

“I think he knows the pointy end goes in the enemy,” Allistair grunted, wiping his mouth with the back of his hand. “Wprd is he’s lethal with a blade.”

“Hang reputations! They are just noise made to scare people,” Lina countered, her words tumbling out fast and fierce. “Elliot is a coxcomb, a fool. His words boast of his might, but he’s a coward underneath. Disarm him, and it’s a fair fight. You can win that. There is no better grappler in Chesterfield than you.”

“Disarm him?” Allistair scoffed. “That is my plan, sweatheart, but have you ever tried grabbing a man’s burning hand holding a broadsword?”

“No,” Lina admitted, flashing a reckless grin. “Honestly, you champions tend to make fights look fairly easy. Do you really think if people realized the danger you are in or the pain of fights that they would look at it as entertainment?”

She had a point – people loved a hero right up until the blood stained their boots. Honestly, he wished he could stay there and talk to her. After all, talking to a beautiful maiden was much more pleasant than stepping into a fight with a man who was trying to butcher him.

Yet, he handed the flask back to Lina, nodded, and stepped over to take his place. He bent his knees and widened his stance, as he always did before grappling. No, that wouldn’t work. He shifted to a lighter stance built for dodging. Why had he accepted the conditions? It was feckin' foolish. Elliot was part crevan, specifically ram. That meant that he’d be strong and take a hit well. Plus the curved horns looked like they could gore a horse. He also was part Rhys, so he would be able to light his hands on fire. Plus, he had a sword. Allistair was no

match for that. He had good intuition from his mokos half, and raw strength from his giant blood and brutal training. Still, he knew he'd likely be dead soon. He looked over at the crowd. He was fighting for them, for people like Lina. He didn't even know her, but she believed in him. He had to be the people's champion.

The herald stepped in front of the stands and blew his trumpet, the brassy note cutting through the air as the entire crowd erupted into cheers for Allistair.

Elliot immediately drew his sword. Allistair had hoped to get a strike in before he cleared the sheath, but failed. All he could do was run away.

Allistair jumped back. Elliot swung strike after strike, the heavy blade whistling inches from Allistair's chest, and Allistair could do nothing but retreat.

The crowd was chanting "Fight… Fight… Fight," but Allistair knew better than to act rashly. He quickly glanced around, his thoughts flipping rapidly, trying to take in the surrounding to get an idea, and spotted the split-rail fence the people sat behind. That would do it.

His thoughts distracted him, so he dodged a split second too late. Elliot grazed him with his sword, the cold steel slicing open his side. The cut was shallow, but warm blood immediately soaked into his tunic, bringing a sharp, stinging ache.

At least Allistair wasn't dead. He pressed his hand against the wound to stem the bleeding and sprinted toward the fence. Of course Elliot charged after him, lowering his horns like a battering ram.

With Elliot right on his heels, Allistair planted a boot on the bottom rail of the fence, vaulted upward, and executed a clean backflip over Elliot. The instant

Allistair's boots hit the dirt behind Elliot, he grabbed Elliot and slammed him hard against the ground.

As Elliot fell, Allistair kicked the sword from his hand and dove on top of him. Allistair had the strength advantage, but Elliot clamped his burning hands onto Allistair's arm, the smell of blistered skin hit Allistair's nostrils instantly, and the searing pain made focusing on the fight almost impossible.

Allistair felt like the fire was coursing straight through his veins, cooking him like a roasted boar, but he couldn't let Elliot win. He gritted his teeth in agony, twisted around, and rolled backward to break the grip. As he scrambled up, Elliot did too. They both faced off, both with eyes burning with determination.

"Now you die!" Elliot seethed, flaring his hand with roaring flames and lowering his horns to charge again.

Allistair's right arm was burned badly. He couldn't throw a hit with it, so he jumped up, wrapped both legs around Elliot's shoulders, and used his own weight to pull him down to the ground.

Elliot grabbed Allistair's right leg and started burning it, searing through his trousers, but Allistair planted his foot firmly on the ground and drove a brutal kick with his left heel straight into Elliot's temple, knocking him out cold.

Allistair stumbled and almost fell to the ground, but he caught himself with one hand in the dirt and pushed himself up quickly. Then he turned to the crowd and raised his good fist in victory. The crowd roared, and he tried to keep a smile on his face so they wouldn't see the agony of the burns and bruises.

A short, brown-haired maiden with green eyes and

delicate, translucent wings fluttered out onto the field. That was expected. The brown-haired, green-eyed, winged race was the faunen. They weren't strong, but had a great touch with nature. Their gardens produced well, and although they couldn't speak to animals, they had a way with them. Their best quality was that they could also heal. That was what the maiden was coming to do. She went first to Elliot, as he was unconscious.

While she healed him, the crowd came onto the field and surrounded Allistair. He really didn't feel well enough to handle the crowd. He'd been burned and cut, the world spinning around him, his head so disoriented that he had a hard time standing, but he put on a good face as Lina and Hartley ran over, helped him up, and hooked his arms over their shoulders to steady him.

"Good job," Hartley assured him, grinning. "You won. I guess I don't get to go loot your room after all."

"Very funny," Allistair rasped through clenched teeth. "I'd come up with a sharp comeback, but my brain is cooked. I need to sleep."

"We need to get you to the faunen," Lina insisted, her voice tight with worry. "You need healing."

"Feckin' brilliant," Allistair mumbled. "Let's go see the magic fairy."

"Let him through," Lina called to the crowd, planting her free hand on her hip. "Don't make me have to force any of you back." No one took that comment as a threat, as she said it with a smile and looked as if a strong breeze could knock her over. After all, she was a beautiful, petite sprite.

The crowd did part to let Allistair through, and he forced a smile for them as he limped by. But his smile

suddenly died as the crowd parted to reveal someone blocking his path.

Allistair suddenly found himself face to face with Elliot.

Their eyes met in silent combat until Elliot threatened in a low, venomous voice, “You are going to regret this. I promise you will. I am a powerful man and a bad enemy to have.”

Chapter 3: Ale, Songs, and One Hard Punch

Allistair didn't find the faunen in the crowd, and she didn't find him, so he and Hartley headed to the Red Wolf Tavern and Inn. They'd been there many times. Jacob, the owner of the tavern, would be expecting them to come after the tournament.

Allistair and Hartley walked in the door with Allistair's side still trickling blood and his arm and leg visibly burned.

"Do you want to go to a room and get cleaned up?" Jacob asked, the lines around his eyes showing his age, but his broad shoulders showing he was still strong. "You aren't looking so good. I understand how that goes. I had my share of fights when I was your age. I was a champion too. Have I told you about the time I stopped the stampede of wild boars and we cooked them up and feasted?"

"Only about a hundred times, old man," Allistair muttered, leaning heavily against a timber bar to keep his

legs from buckling. “Look, I love a good pork story as much as the next guy, but I’m currently bleeding all over your floor. Unless one of those boars is gonna carry me upstairs, skip the tale and get me a bed.”

“Sorry,” Jacob mumbled. “Yet, those were the days… Before chimeric beasts and high taxes.” He glanced around the room before whispering, “Do you know there were actually still some wizards then?”

That caught Allistair’s attention. Magic had been destroyed over a hundred years ago. There had been rumors of a few remaining sorcerers, but they were feared, hunted down, and killed. People feared to even talk of sorcery. Yet, Allistair mumbled, “Weren’t wizards evil, or is that just more nonsense the crown feeds us?”

“Some were,” Jacob admitted. “Yet, some were very benign. Magic still exists north of the mountains north of Arwood. Yet, I shouldn’t mention it.” He leaned even closer, his voice barely audible. “I had a fairy who worked for me. There was a time where a drunken man tried to force himself on her, and she cast a spell on him and turned his head into that of a donkey.” He sighed. “It wore off, but those two weeks were incredible. Unfortunately, she had to flee back up north for her life.” He glanced around again, as a nervous mouse watching for a cat. “I shouldn’t talk of magic. You fought well today, and saved the town three hundred silver pieces. Your first drink tonight is on me.”

Allistair was stumbling toward the stairs to go to a room to clean up, when the same faunen who had healed Elliot walked into the tavern. “I’ve come to heal you,” she offered in a bright, joyful voice, as she walked right up to him.

“I won’t turn down a pretty magic fairy healing me,” Allistair grunted, leaning against a wooden wall. “Turns out getting cut and roasted alive hurts a bit.”

She took him to a room and had him take off his blood-stained shirt and lie on a bed. When he did, she eyed his muscles and commented, “This isn’t going to be a bad way to earn a copper piece.”

“What?” Allistair mumbled, too delirious from the loss of blood to get too worried. “Hold on… Are you charging me? I’m flat broke.”

“No” the faunen assured him. “You owe me nothing.”

“What? Somebody’s actually helping just to be kind?” Allistair slurred, his face buried in the bed.

“Oh, no,” the faunen corrected. “I’m getting paid, just not by you. Lord Urvan hired me to come to the tournament and heal anyone who needed healing there. I bargained for an extra copper for you since I had to come here.”

That surprised Allistair. She looked so innocent with her long brown hair, deep green eyes, and iridescent wings, as if she’d heal anyone just from the goodness of her heart. He tried to shake his head, but it made him dizzy. “Feckin’ little mercenary.”

She shrugged innocently. “A girl has to make a living.”

Then she put her hands on his wounds, as that was the normal way faunens healed. The only other race who had healing ability was the elves. They healed by holding crystals and blowing on people. It would stabilize someone, but not heal as well as faunens could.

“This is better than burning,” Allistair sighed as a healing warmth spread from her palms through him. “Though I gotta say, I’d recover twice as fast if you healed with kisses.”

“I get that request often,” the faunen smirked. “If I could, it would cost a lot more than a copper to get me to heal you.”

“What?” Allistair blurted out. “Did I hear you right? You have a price tag? You little minx.”

“I’m joking,” she assured him. “I am not the type who can be paid for favors. I’m no doxy. I am glad I heal the way I do. I would not want to have had to kiss Elliot today. Trust me that Urvan could not have paid me enough to do that.”

“He’s tough enough to heal on his own,” Allistair grunted. “If not, he deserves some pain.”

The faunen shrugged. “Perhaps. Perhaps not. You kicked him hard.” She smiled demurely and added, “You are very strong,” as she continued to gently glide her warm hands across his toned chest.

Allistair let out a long, slow, relaxing breath as the searing pain began to fade. “If I can’t get a kiss, how about at least telling me your name?”

“Raissa,” the beautiful, winged maiden replied. “You don’t have to tell me who you are. Everyone around knows who you are.”

“Only the ones paying a copper to watch me bleed at tournaments,” Allistair muttered dryly.

Raissa put her hand on his neck, and the bruises and soreness began to vanish.

“I like the laurel wreath markings around your neck,” she commented as she healed him.

He startled, bolting up so fast he nearly knocked her over. “Laurel wreath? What?”

She went over to a table that had a small hand mirror on it and brought it over to him. He stared into it, as shocked as if he’d just opened the winning pouch to see gold instead of silver. “Holy feck! That’s new.”

“You definitely earned it,” Raissa beamed. “A laurel wreath is a symbol of triumph, and you definitely triumphed today.”

“Did I?” Allistair muttered, still staring in the mirror, his fingers brushing along the mark. “Look at the game they are playing, Raissa. They ride in demanding five hundred silver, I bleed in the dirt to knock it down to two hundred, and now the whole town is cheering like we won a war, forgetting we are getting robbed blind. That’s still a two hundred silver piece extra tax.”

He set the hand mirror on the table with a dull thud. “It’s the oldest trick in the book. Threaten to take everything, take half instead, and the people will thank you for it while picking their pockets. The people will now be happy that their extra tax is less than half of what was demanded instead of being infuriated that there is an extra tax at all. I don’t believe half the stories the crown feeds us about those kingdoms across the mountains. They’re likely lies to scare people into paying up.”

Raissa gazed at him, taking in every word he said. “Wise. Of course, I should have expected that from you.”

“What?” Allistair laughed. “Everyone thinks because I throw punches for copper, I’m too dumb to count. I’m glad you notice that I’ve got plenty between my ears.” He

winked at her and added, “The muscle is just a nice bonus.”

Raissa blushed. “You do, and I admit I have been guilty of assuming you were all brawn, but when I healed you, I saw the markings on your left arm. You have an inkwell with fire coming from it and a martlet coming from the fire. That makes quite the statement about you. The inkwell is a symbol of literacy. You must know how to read and write. That is unusual for this town.”

Allistair flexed his arm to see how well the healing had worked. “My parents were dead set on me learning to read and write.”

Raissa tilted her head curiously. “I haven’t heard of your father. Should I have?”

“Why would you?” Allistair replied with a dry smirk. “He’s a carpenter, not some lord sitting in a stone tower, so the martlet is fitting. Nobody handed me a title or a bag of gold. Everything I have, I bled for and built myself.”

“Impressive,” Raissa muttered before speaking up so Allistair could hear. “The fire is obvious why you have that. You definitely have passion for what you do.”

Allistair shrugged, a half-grin tugging at he mouth, though Raissa couldn’t tell if he was agreeing or disagreeing. She rubbed her warm hand along his ear and cheek before stepping back. “I’m done. I can’t heal everything with as badly as you were wounded. You’ll be sore for a while, but you won’t have any permanent damage from the cut. It was worse than you thought. Your ear was sliced almost off. I don’t think you even noticed that with all the shock you were in, but it may have lasting effects.”

“Shock?” Allistair grunted, reaching up to feel his ear. “Well, that explains why the ceiling was spinning and I nearly agreed to pay you for kisses.”

Raissa once again ran her hand down his face and chest. “I really can do no more. Perhaps you should go back to the main room and enjoy the celebration. Many people will want to congratulate you tonight.”

He stood up and startedputting his shirt on. Raissa shook her head, smiling at the sight. “What a waste, hiding a chest like that under a shirt. That is one enjoyable benefit about being a healer. I do get to see handsome fighters shirtless. Even better, I get paid for it.” Her eyes went wide and her tone serious. “Of course, not everyone I see is as handsome as you, and I do have to see a great deal of blood and gore. There is a very dark side to my job, but at least I can counter some of the horror by being the light amid the gloom and saving people from death.”

Allistair reached down, as she was over a foot shorter than him, looked in her eyes, and merely responded, “Thank you.” He stayed looking in her eyes for a moment. He’d been healed by her before, as she often was the healer for tournaments in Chesterfield, but he’d never had a conversation with her. Never had he thought of how a faunen must feel putting her hands on a bloody wound or seeing someone dying in front of her and hoping she could heal him.

“You’re welcome,” she responded. “I am happy to have helped.”

“Because you are a copper wealthier?” he teased.

She smiled. “That doesn’t hurt. I might as well make money off what I do. After all, you make money off what

you do."

Allistair rolled his eyes. "Only if I win."

Raissa tensed as she admitted, "I don't generally get paid if I can't heal someone and he dies. Don't think my job is easy. You don't have lives depending on you."

That was true. Perhaps sometimes he'd talk to Raissa and really learn of the faunen. There weren't that many in most cities, as most faunen lived in Bellemar, an island off the east coast. It was inhabited by faunen and courtites, a race of very small people, about three to four feet tall. They were rumored to be excellent gardeners, to love food, and to have a simple life. The noble house there, the house of Garnier, was courtites, but people knew little of them, as they kept to themselves.

Once Allistair had put his shirt and tunic on, he and Raissa headed back to the main room. He was eager to get there, as he wanted to get a hero's kiss from a beautiful maiden, and he knew exactly which one.

The room was loud, so loud that it was hard to hear the lute player, but when Allistair walked into the room, a man roared over the noise, "He's here!"

The crowd raised their mugs and called out, "Huzzah!"

Allistair raised his fists in acknowledgment and cut through the noisy taproom to find Jacob. "I'm ready for that drink, old man," he grunted.

Jacob didn't even look up from the mug he was filling. "Posset or braggot?"

Allistair raised his eyebrows, staring at Jacob as if he'd grown a second head. "Hold on. Did I hear you right? You're actually pouring top-shelf braggot or

posset? Feckin' glorious!"

Jacob turned around and met his eyes. "You saved the town three hundred silver pieces. You know, one time, I rescued a maiden from bandits, and I was given free posset for a month, as the tavern owner in Roifort, where I was, wanted his son to marry her. I'm not giving you free posset or braggot for a month, just one drink, but I think you deserve it. You saved the town three hundred silver pieces."

Allistair clenched his lips for a moment. The people weren't really saving money. They just weren't paying as high of an extra tax. They should all be upset about that, not celebrating a decrease in the tyranny. Yet, Allistair wasn't going to turn down the fancy drink. After all, posset was a spicy creamy wine, with milk and spices definitely good for a healing tonic, and braggot was a rich honey meade, spiced with ginger and cloves, and generally used for celebrations.

"Braggot," Allistair decided.

Jacob filled a mug of braggot and handed it to Allistair, who took it, thanked him, and went over and sat at the table Hartley was at.

"Can I have one of those?" Hartley teased, seeing the braggot. "If you'd told me there was braggot as a reward, maybe I'd have fought Elliot."

Allistair chuckled in response, but made no snide comment because a serving wench with bunny ears and a tail walked over to him. She had very curly hair that came just past her shoulders. Likely, her eyes were some color, but no man ever looked at her eyes with her figure and how low her blouse was cut. She sat beside him and gave him a very passionate hero's kiss. After the kiss, she

rubbed her hand along his shoulders and offered, “When I’m done working, perhaps I can give you an even better hero’s reward.”

He answered her by giving her another kiss. After all, he knew her well. Her name was Sephora, and she was very friendly. It wasn’t the first time he’d kissed her. The crowd around him cheered. He picked up his mug, raised it to them, and then took a drink. Braggot was good. There was a reason it was considered a drink to celebrate a hero.

Sephora winked at him and teased, “Maybe someday you’ll ask me to marry you.” She looked over her shoulder as she turned to get back to work. Allistair watched her go, then went back to enjoying his drink. One that good needed to be savored.

As he swished the braggot around in his mouth to enjoy every spice, Lina stood up in front of everyone and called the noisy crowd to order. Everyone immediately became quiet.

Allistair almost didn’t recognize her, as she’d changed her hair to brown with purple highlights, where it had been blond with pink tips earlier that day, a common problem as many sprites changed their coloring often. She had also changed her clothing. Instead of a formal ceremonial dress, she wore a billowy-sleeved peasant blouse between a fitted burgundy bodice, fastened with small leather buckles and cinched by a wide brown belt. The hip flaps rested over a layered, asymmetric skirt, split up the front to show dark leggings and tall boots. Around her neck, she wore a crystal pendant on a thin chain.

“It’s that time of night,” Lina hollered, hopping onto

a sturdy wooden table with boundless energy. “Prepare to be amazed!”

Everyone knew what she meant, as Jacob had been boasting all evening that she would be singing that night.

The crowd cheered for Lina, clapping and stomping their boots, so she waved her hands wildly to get them quiet. “I’m thrilled to be raising the roof off this place tonight! Are we ready to make some noise?”

The crowd roared back, so she hushed them with a dramatic finger to her lips, and started into a fast, spirited tune, her fingers flying across her lute.

When she finished, she waited for the applause to crescendo, and then called out, “For my next song, who’s brave enough to step up and sing with me?”

No one dared to sing with her except one drunken man who raised his mug, tried to stand up, and immediately passed out cold before taking two steps.

Lina planted her hands on her hips, scanning the room. Was no one really going to take her offer?

“I’ll sing,” Allistair called out, setting his mug down on the table.

“You sing?” Lina asked, her eyes lighting up as everyone in the room gasped in surprise. After all, fighters don’t sing, do they?

Allistair shook his head as he looked around, knowing exactly what they were all thinking, that he could do nothing but fight. He shrugged and walked up to Lina, “I don’t know how well I sing, sweetheart, and I’m definitely no choir boy, but I love music. Let’s do it.”

Lina strummed a few lively bars, and they both

started singing. Allistair knew the words. Everyone knew the words, as she was playing a common folk song.

At the end of the song, the crowd erupted. Lina pointed to dramatically to Allistair, so he took a deep, showman's bow.

When he straightened up, she leaned in close, her eyes glinting with mischief, and whispered, "How are you at improvising lyrics?"

He raised his eyebrows. "Guess we're about to find out. Honestly, I'd rather have time to sit down with parchment and ink, map out my thoughts, organize them, and make the verses sharp."

"Well, you have five seconds to do that," Lina teased as she picked her lute up and started strumming. "Keep up big guy – let's go!"

She then began singing:

"I'm one who has to make her way, through song and wit and fun,
I entertain with energy. I really aim to stun.
I'm not afraid to be myself with dukes or king's or knights.
So don't expect apologies. I'm me, a playful sprite."

She pointed to Allistair and played a few bars of a bridge to give him time to think.

Allistair was supposed to come up with lyrics on the spot with everyone watching, every eye in the room glued on him. Sweat suddenly beaded on his forehead. He'd rather go into a grappling match. There, he knew the rules. All he had to do was punch people. Yet, he was singing, not fighting. He'd have to accept that his verse

wouldn’t be perfect. He glanced the crowd. At least he wouldn’t take a beating in front of them. Finally, his eyes caught Lina’s. She smiled at him, calming his nerves, and he sang:

> “I want to live and die my dream. I want to make my way.
> My path’s not clear to be the man I want to be someday.
> For now I’ll live and seize the day with fights and ale and ham.
> I’m trying to enjoy my life, just being who I am.”

Lina then started singing a chorus:

> “Who I am. Who I am. I’ll be true to who I am.
> Who I am. Who I am. I like being who I am.”

It didn’t take long for Allistair to pick up on the tune and start singing along.

When they finished, the noisy crowd hollered for more. Allistair looked out over them with his eyebrows raised. His words were thrown together quickly, not polished at all, so he wasn’t sure why the people were so excited. Then again, half of them were drunk. He could likely make up a rhyme about squirrels who steal the people’s food, so the people eat them fried and stewed, and still have the drunks laugh at it. Still, he’d enjoy the applause. He’d watched minstrels sing and always wanted to do it.

Lina let him go sit back down and sang a song that started off,

"Do you like me just now, how I've changed,
how I've grown?
Zounds! I'll tell you straight out that I'm full of
unknown.
I'm short but bold. Don't mess with me.
I'll make you smile quite easily."

Allistair smiled as he listened to her song. Her energy and innocent look captivated him, but there was more to her – she had spunk! Perhaps sometimes he could hear her story.

He went back to his braggot as he listened to her playful tunes. When he finished his drink, he ordered another, that time a plain ale, as he was paying. He had won some money, so he could splurge a little, but he had debts to pay too.

He and Hartley kept drinking until almost everyone had cleared out for the night. When Hartley fell asleep with his cheek pressed against the hard table, Allistair pushed himself up, walked heavily over to the bar, and dropped on a wooden stool, slamming his mug on the counter, splashing dark ale, and glared at Jacob. "What is wrong with everyone? People so stupid... The crown invents a new tax out of thin air, and everyone just bends over and takes it without question. Yeah, I'm glad I bled to knock it down, but nobody should be cheerig. They shouldn't be paying a single feckin' copper extra. They throw a little music and a wrestling match in front of them, and suddenly everyone's blind to the fact that they're still getting robbed. When are they going to open their eyes?"

Before Jacob could answer, Allistair finished his mug and then closed his eyes as he swayed on the stool and his

head dropped onto the counter with a dull thud. Teh impact jolted him wide awake, and he snapped upright, blinking rapidly, on high alert.

“People are too trusting,” Jacob agreed. “Back in my day, we handled our own problems. Sure, kings have always made laws, but we didn’t want them in our lives too much.” He sighed. “Honestly, I don’t know if the kingdom west of the mountain is a threat or not. In my day, I’d have gone over there and had a look for myself, but times have changed.”

Allistair responded by again swaying and having his head fall on the counter with a thud. When it hit, the impact again jolted him awake and he snapped back up. “I’m listening.”

Jacob shook his head. His stories would have to wait. “Perhaps you just aren’t thinking clearly. You’ve had a few too many ales tonight. Go to a room.”

“Maybe I feckin’ should,” Allistair muttered, tipping his mug over and giving it a shake, seeing that he’d drained every drop. “Bed sounds like a solid plan. Didn’t Sephora make me an offer? My head’s too foggy to remember, but she’s a dream.” He rubbed his head. “Dreams… Was I dreaming, or did I really get up and sing in front of the whole taproom?”

“Yes, and you were good,” Jacob answered, wiping the counter with a damp rag. “Now, go to sleep before you do something foolish.”

“I like being feckin’ foolish,” Allistair laughed, hitting his hand on the counter. “Truth is, I make a living out of it.” He looked at his empty mug. If only that was true. The drink wasn’t all for fun. Even with his fame as a tournament fighter, and crowds cheering for him,

carrying the weight of a rigged would was exhausting. He didn't reach for the ale because he wanted tohave fun. He drank to escape reality.

"Go to bed," Jacob urged. "Seriously, you've had too much."

Allistair stood up, but wobbled, trying to get his balance by holding onto the stool. He spun around for a moment, trying to figure out which way was the hall to the rooms. It was far too late to try to make it home.

He stumbled toward the fuzzy hallway, but lost his balance and fell to the floor as the door flew open. Elliot strutted in, his head held high. Two lesser knights flanked him, one on each side.

Elliot stormed over, grabbed Allistair's shirt, and pulled him up to a sitting position. "Look at you now. You're pathetic," Elliot mocked. He leaned in, hissing in Allistair's face, "I warned you that you would regret beating me." He pulled his free hand back and struck Allistair with a right hook.

Allistair saw the hit coming, yet the ale had turned his limbs to lead. His brain screamed at him to block, but his body didn't respond. The blow cracked across his jaw like an iron mallet, lighting up his skull in a blinding flash before the tavern floor rushed up to meet him – and everything went black.

Elliot stood up, sneered down at him unconscious on the floor and threatened, "You are going to regret humiliating me."

Chapter 4: A Challenge, Disappointment, and a Hangover

The next morning, Allistair woke up with a splitting headache and barely able to remember the night before. He stumbled down the hall, then realized he hadn't put his jerkin on and headed back to his room. Not being coherent, he opened the wrong door, and a couple in it startled.

"Sorry, ma'am," he mumbled as he started to close the door. Then his eyes popped suddenly awake. "Sephora!" he screamed, turning back around to the couple. "What are you doing?"

Sephora pulled the covers up to her chin. "I can explain, but perhaps now is not the time."

Allistair slammed the door, shaking the doors around, and walked down the hall. The main room was quiet, probably because it was almost noon. Allistair sat

on a stool at the counter and muttered, “I think I need a feckin’ drink.”

“I’ll get you something to sober you up,” Jacob offered. “I have a special drink just for that. I learned it after I had a few too many and… Never mind. That’s a story I’m not going to tell. Just drink it. It’s an infusion in water of milk thistle, dandelion, and ginger.” He handed the mug to Allistair.

Allistair took the mug and drank deeply, letting the cool liquid wash away the bitter taste in his mouth. After a few swallows, he let out a dry, humorless laugh. “Forget the morning tonic, Jacob. Pour me another ale. Turns out I just walked in on Sephora tangled up with some other man.”

“I’ve warned you about her before,” Jacob pointed out, shaking his head. “She’ll tell you how exceptional you are, but tells every other man the exact same thing.”

“Yeah, well, apparently I’m a feckin’ slow learner,” Allistair grunted. He slapped his hand on the counter, immediately wincing as the sharp crack echoed in his already throbbing head. Gritting his teeth against the hangover, he squinted toward the taproom window. “What’s the hour?”

“Almost noon,” Jacob answered.

“Sards!!” Allistair snapped, jumping off the stool. “I’m late!”

Jacob shoved some rye bread at him and helped him out the door.

Allistair hurriedly saddled his horse and galloped to work. He hired out helping build homes, as he was good with wood. His father was a woodworker, but he didn’t

work for his father.

As he rode up to the site of the house he was to work on, his master stormed up to him, yelling, “You’re late again!”

The yelling hammer through Allistair’s pounding head, but he swung down from his horse and forced himself to stand up straight. “Look, I’m sorry,” he rasped, squinting against the noon sun. “There was a tournament yesterday. Did you not hear that I won it, and that I bled to knock that rotten extra tax down by over half? My ribs are still aching today, and my ear is ringing.”

“I did hear about that,” his master snapped, crossing his arms over his sawdust-covered tunic. “I’d forgive today, if you didn’t stumble in past noon every other week smelling like ale. I’ve given you chance after chance, Allistair, but in the state you’re in, you are likely to drop a tree on someone. Go home. I will not pay you anymore. You are dismissed.”

Dismissed? Had he heard right? Allistair stared at the master, the ale-fog burning away in an instant. “Hold on –”

“No excuses!” the master barked, pointing a calloused finger toward the road. “Go!”

Allistair fought back tears. It wasn’t manly to cry, but despite his success in tournaments, life was hard. What would he do? Where would he go? He had some money from the win the day before, but he’d have to find another source of money soon. Even winning tournaments didn’t pay well enough to live off of.

He mounted his horse, slumping over the reins, and started heading back to the Red Wolf.

As he walked into the tavern, he was surprised to see Lina there. Her hair was a creamy peach color that was stunning with her soft features. She was playing her lute and singing for the people while they at their noon day meal.

Allistair pulled up a chair and sat backward on it, leaning on the back to watch. Her song seemed hopeful amid the gloom, but there was a melancholy undertone. Life likely hadn't always been easy for her.

Allistair was pretty good at reading people. Most mokos were. Still, there was a great deal he didn't know. People only saw the face Lina put on as a minstrel, and he knew quite well that people's public face wasn't always real. He was pretty true to himself, but still, there were days he put on a smile and waved to the crowd even though he didn't feel like fighting. Everyone who participated in the tournaments knew that if they didn't put on a good show that the tournaments would stop and they wouldn't make money.

Money… He definitely was going to need more after losing his job.

Jacob walked up to him and handed him another of his hangover remedies to drink.

Allistair drank it as he watched Lina, gazing at her beauty and captivated by her song.

When she finished her grand finale, she passed the hat, then bounced over and sat down by Allistair.

"If you are looking for a coin, you're barking up the wrong tree." Allistair quipped, staring into his mug. "Seriously, tournament purses barely cover bandages, and I was just booted out the gate at my day job."

Lina smiled at him, placing her hand on his arm. He half expected her to feed her some really sweet, consoling nonsense, but instead she laughed brightly. “Their loss. Look, forget this dusty town. Would you like to come sing with me in Roifort? That city is loaded with gold. The nobles should tip tip minstrels well.”

“You really want me… me... to sing with you?” Allistair asked, raising a skeptical eyebrow.

“It makes total sense,” Lina rattled off. “I think you should try it until the next tournament at least.”

Allistair leaned forward and pressed, “Do you think I’m that good of a singer?”

“You’re good enough,” Lina replied with a cheeky grin. She then leaned closer, lowering her voice below the taproom chatter. “All right, full honestly – I have an ulterior motive. The lands have been getting more violent and beasts have been attacking up north. It isn’t safe for a maiden to travel alone anymore.”

“Ah, there it is,” Allistair muttered with a knowing grin. “So you want me as a bodyguard, not a singing partner.”

“I want you as both,” Lina corrected, tapping his arm. “You bring the muscle and the harmonies. I bring the charm and energy to attract the crowd. Now, is it a deal?”

“Do you really trust me?” Allistair countered, his expression hardening. “I just caught the lady I thought loved me tangled up with another man. I lost my job. And half the town knows I drink too much.”

Lina shrugged, seemingly unbothered. “You aren’t a saint, big guy, but I think you are solid. I’d rather take my

chances on the road with you than take my chances getting mauled by a beast or robbed blind. The thieves guild has been running wild lately. Crime is through the roof."

"If I were a Knight Avant I'd tear that guild apart," Allistair growled, his jaw tightening. "Unfortunately, because I bleed in the arena for a copper, everyone assumes I have rocks for brains. Nobody listens to a word I say unless I'm grappling."

Lina's face lit up. "Then perhaps you'll enjoy singing with me. People treat actresses like dirt, yet minstrels are the ones carrying news from town to town, so folks assume we know more than we often do."

Allistair nodded. "Do you travel often?"

"I try not to more than I must," Lina admitted. "Remember the whole not safe for a lady to travel alone part I just mentioned." She sighed, her bright mask slipping for a second. "Still, I have to move around plenty."

Allistair leaned back a little, his eyes fixed on her face as he thought. "Sards, I'm sure you have plenty of men lining up to travel with you."

"Perhaps," Lina smirked, "though most of them are feckless fools. I can see by your markings that you actually have a brain in your head. What do you say? Do we head to Roifort?"

"Let me think on it," Allistair suggested. "When do you want to leave?"

"Tomorrow," she answered promptly. "Although I can wait if I must."

Allistair nodded. "I want to say good-bye to my

family, and Hartley too. Don't worry. They live near."

Lina leaned forward with an eager, curious smile. "How big of a family do you have?"

"Parents and a sister," Allistair answered, genuine warmth softening his voice. "They are good people." Lina noticeably tensed. Allistair caught it. "Okay, I take it you aren't really close to yours."

"I've been surviving on my own since I was fifteen," she admitted. "Don't dig too deep. I don't talk about my past." She looked at him like a lost kitten and sheepishly added, "I guess I should admit that part of my fear of traveling alone is that Counselor Florence hates my guts. That could be dangerous."

"Counselor Florence?" Allistair scoffed. "She's a feckin' fool. How could she hurt you?"

"She could hire blades," Lina whispered, glancing toward the tavern door. "I wouldn't put it past her for a second. I don't even know her well. I only met her once. I was singing in the Pewter Rose – that's a tavern for nobles – and she tried to have me thrown in chains. I think I offended her because I have a way of spitting out the ugly truth without sugarcoating it, or perhaps…" She stopped, biting her lip. "Nevermind." She paused in thought for a heartbeat, then added, "Or maybe it's because the lord she was with couldn't stop complimented my appearance."

Allistair again noticed a vulnerability to her, as she looked like a child worried she would get hit by her drunken father. He gently picked up her hand, looked in her eyes, and assured her, "You have a new partner and bodyguard. I've made my decision."

She threw her arms around him excitedly.

She was hugging him when the door flew open and Elliot stormed in the room. He strutted over to Allistair and insisted, “Stand up!”

Lina jumped up. Allistair stood up, in front of her to protect her, and with a glare that could burn through iron asked, “What do you want?”

Elliot pulled a glove from his belt and slapped Allistair across the face with it. “I challenge you to a rematch for my honor, two days hence, at high noon. Do you accept?”

“No,” Allistair answered calmly. “I don’t care about your honor, and I’m leaving in the morning.”

Elliot reached for his sword. Allistair knew better than to let him, so he jumped up and kicked Elliot back.

Elliot hit a table, rolled over it, and fell to the floor.

“Let’s go,” Allistair urged Lina.

He grabbed her hand and ran out the door with her. As the crossed the threshold, Elliot pushed up to his knees and called to them, “Allistair watch your back. You can run, but you can’t hide!”

Chapter 5: A Story, A Brawl, and a Pretty Dance Partner

Two days traveling north through woods and plains in Lina's wagon with both their horses pulling it brought Allistair and Lina to the Pewter Rose in Roifort, a grand city crowned by the towering stone of the king's castle.

Lina gazed up at the castle walls. "Perhaps we'll get to sing for the king."

Allistair stepped out of the wagon, tied the horses, and helped Lina down as she rambled, "Could you see me singing for the king?" She scrunched her eyebrows as she considered it. "No, Counselor Florence might be there, and I probably shouldn't go near the throne. I'm way too bold, with too much mouth for a royal court I'd probably tell tell to lower taxes, and remind him a king is supposed to serve his people, not shackle them in chains."

“That would land you in the dungeon quick enough,” Allistair quipped. “While we’re dreaming, what do you think my odds of becoming a Knight Avant are?”

“If you can get a shot, great,” Lina chirped. “You are strong, sharp, and brave.” She flashed him a bright grin and tacked on, “You are fun to travel with too – way better company than just my horse.”

Allistair chuckled. “Glad to know I edged out the gelding. Do you have a dog? I wouldn’t even try to compete there.”

“No dog,” she assured him.

They finished tying the horses and stepped into the Pewter Rose. It didn’t look like a normal tavern. The ceiling was high, and many windows let in warm sunlight, so even though it was nearing twilight, the room wasn’t dark and only candle lit. There was a platform at the front of the room. On it, a winged faunen maiden played a pennywhistle while a gati played a drum, and a male sprite played the lute and sang.

Lina nodded. “They are actually really good.”

“They are,” Allistair agreed. “A gati as a drummer is a crafty. Their extra thumb on each hand gives them ridiculous dexterity. That beat is feckin’ glorious.”

They sat on a bench at a table, watching the performers, drawn into the music. They were rather so hooked that they hardly noticed the serving maiden came stepping up to their table to ask what they wanted.

“What’s on the fire tonight?” Allistair asked.

“Roast beef, barley salad, apples, and manchet bread,” the maiden answered. “There’s water, juice, milk, or ale to wash it down.”

Allistair blinked, caught off guard. Had he heard her right? They were having roast beef, not just pottage, and salad, apples, and bread? In Chesterfield, eating beef was a luxury. Folks had venison and fish fairly often, but cows were expensive, and the people who could afford them used them for milk, not for meat. The Red Wolf served pottage with little meat and bread almost every night. That was it.

The prices dealt him a second shock, and settled on one dish to split with an extra piece of bread and just water to drink.

“I’d fight for an ale tonight,” Allistair grumbled, “but we don’t know how full our hats will get in Roifort, so we need to keep the purse strings tight.”

Lina rolled a shoulder. “I’ll be fine without ale. It will be exciting to see what you’re like in a tavern stone sober. Your jokes may actually be funny.”

Allistair gave a forced chuckle, unsure if he’d just been complimented or insulted.

Their food came quickly, and they ate keeping their eyes on the musicians. The sprite had a rich, effortless voice, which wasn’t surprising, as most sprites were born with music in their blood.

The notes carried clearly across the room, as the tavern wasn’t as noisy or bawdy as the Red Wolf. Perhaps due to the hulky giant by the door who escorted anyone who was in a drunken roar out.

“I wish I had the natural talent of a sprite,” Allistair admitted, his gaze fixed on the stage. “My giant blood gives me muscle, sure, but the mokos half just carves my whole life story into my skin.” He pulled up his left sleeve motioned to his forearm. “You have no idea what

it’s like walking around with your life on your arm for every stranger to judge. Sure, the inkwell shows I can read, which is great. But the martlet? That shows I wasn’t born into wealth or a title. It’s a bird with no feet, so it also shows that I have had to work hard from the start and will never get to land until I die. It’s not a marking I’m proud of.”

Lina smiled encouragingly. “Maybe one day it will be. Some day it may be a badge of glory that you succeeded as the martlet.”

Allistair shook his head. “You wouldn’t understand. You are a full-blooded, beautiful sprite.”

“I’ve been through plenty of dirt you don’t know about,” Lina shot back. She leaned over and whispered, “I’m not full sprite. I can’t change my skin color or eyes, only my hair. I am actually part mokos and part elf, just not enough elf to have pointed ears, but where do you think I get all my chaotic energy from?”

“You’re part mokos?” Allistair echoes, his expression showing no more belief than if she’d just tried to sell him a miracle elixir that could instantly give him all the knowledge in the world and cure stupidity.

She pulled her hair back, revealing that she had markings of delicate flowers cascading down each temple.

Allistair almost touched the marks, but pulled his hand back. “Those look sharp on you. You should be proud of them. You must have done something feckin’ splended to get them.”

“Not necessarily,” Lina corrected, letting her hair fall back over her face. “Yes, they are flowers, but notice the thorns. I’ve had to make my way on my own, and I’ve

made some mistakes along the way." Allistair started to open his mouth, but she held up a finger to quiet him. "I don't tell my past."

Allistair stared at her, looking as if she was a ghost.

"What?" she asked, turning her shoulder to him. "It shouldn't surprise you that I'm part mokos. Very few people are entirely one race. All our races evolved from humans. If history is right and the era of magic had an explosion of magic where it all went into people and created different races, then everyone is human at their core. That's why the races can inter-marry. You shouldn't be surprised that I'm mixed."

Allistair shrugged in acceptance. "Still, I wish I had a drop of sprite blood in me. I love to sing. Mokos aren't gifted with artistic talent naturally, and mokos are the rarest bloodline, so I get stared at like I'm a feckin' sideshow."

"You sing well, and if people are staring it's more likely because you are strong and easy on the eyes," Lina teased, nudging his arm. "Just be yourself and don't worry about what others think. I wish there were more mokos. Mokos, if legend is correct, have the ability to know the truth. They naturally have intuition and understand people. Most mokos are very charismatic. You definitely are."

Allistair shrugged. "I may see the truth. I may know that drinking gets me in trouble, but I still overdo it."

"Why?" Lina pressed softly.

"Life is hard," he quietly replied. "And I'm a martlet."

The song ended, and the musicians took a break.

Oddly enough, they didn't pass a hat, which confused Lina.

She glanced around the room. Would she get in trouble for singing?

She didn't have to think about it because the tavern owner, a rather over-weight crevan with a pig tail called over, "You… minstrel, do you have news to tell us? What's the news of the other cities?"

Lina eagerly hopped up. Perhaps she could earn a few coins. She picked up her lute. "I will be glad to tell stories. Everyone gather around. Hear my tales."

She encouraged people to come sit around as she told stories. She could have been loud enough to be heard all over the room, but she was wise enough to know that if she stood up at the front, many people would only half-listen and would talk to each other, and that very few would feel involved enough to put a coin in her hat.

She gathered people around and began to tell the story of the tournament in Chesterfield. She told of different fights and of the final battle between the giant Theo and the hero Allistair. After she told the story, she played her lute and sang:

"The champion Allistair is bold.
His hero status is foretold.
He'll live and die a hero's dream.
One day his name all will esteem.
He's wise. He's strong. He's full of might,
One day surpassing noble knights,
For legend's heroes can't compare,
To our handsome champion, Allistair!"

She then told of how Allistair saved the city from a

brute demanding money, not mentioning the name of Sir Elliot, but saying Allistair fought him and won. After that, she sang the verse again, changing the last few words:

> “The champion Allistair is bold.
> His hero status is foretold.
> He’ll live and die a hero’s dream.
> One day his name all will esteem.
> He’s wise. He’s strong. He’s full of might,
> One day surpassing noble knights,
> For legend’s heroes can’t compare,
> To our noble hero, Allistair!”

The crowd loved the story, and Lina passed a hat. She had hoped more people would put money in. Quite a few snubbed her, but the people who did put money in were pretty generous.

When the crowd went back to their tables, Lina went back over to Allistair. “I did feckin’ grand!” She excitedly jingled her hat. “I can buy you an ale, but I’m only buying one, as I think it’s best if you stay being a hero to these people.”

He smiled a wry grin. “You didn’t mention that I am Allistair. They don’t see me as a hero.”

Lina waved her hand, blowing the comment off. “They’ll figure it out soon enough. There is method to my madness. If I introduce you at the same time that I tell the story, I pass the hat once. People won’t put in more money that way. They’ll put in the same amount whether I tell two stories or three. In a little while, someone will feel quite proud because he realizes that you are the champion from the story.”

Allistair clasped his hands. “You didn’t mention

Elliot, expose the outrageous tax, or reveal the corruption in..."

"I thought it might get us in trouble," Lina interrupted. "It's best to see how the people here feel about the king and taxing the cities before saying too much. Besides, Elliot has connections. Let's not upset important people. I'm rather fond of my head being on my shoulders."

"Feckin' brilliant," Allistair quipped. "You are much more than a beautiful face."

She blushed and called to the serving wench for an ale.

She was right that someone would notice Allistair. One of the serving wenches asked his name, and it was simple to make the connection.

The lady stood up in front of everyone and announced that Allistair was the hero from the song. Cheers rose through the room, echoing in the vaulted ceiling.

Lina took advantage of the situation and called to the people, "Do you want to see the hero perform?"

The people cheered, so Allistair leaned over to Lina and asked, "You sure about this? What am I supposed to do?"

She smiled excitedly. "Trust me. I won't get you bloodied up too much."

An awkward chuckle burst from his lips, hoping she was joking.

She grabbed his arm, pulled him up onto the platform, and announced, "This is the champion Allistair!

Do you want to hear him sing?”

Cheers again rose to the raftrs, so Lina played a song and she and Allistair sang.

After the song, a crevan man called out, “If you’re such a good fighter, let’s wrestle and see who wins. I’m undefeated.”

Allistair did a double take. The man was obviously part crevan, as he had goat horns on his head. He was tall for a normal crevan, only about three inches shorter than Allistair, so he likely had some giant blood too. He wore a sword, but was not dressed like a knight. If he was one, he was not on duty. Perhaps Allistair had a chance against him.

Lena smacked Allistair on the arm, so he suddenly remembered he needed to reply. “This isn’t the place to fight, not in a classy tavern like this.”

The owner’s voice boomed from across the room, “I’ll allow it. Everyone move the tables.”

Chatter erupted as everyone began moving the tables. Why were they? Allistair hadn’t even agreed to the match. He placed his hand on Lina’s arm and leaned over. “What do I do?”

Lina looked around, sizing up the situation. “I think you can beat him. Actually, I’m confident enough that I may take bets. We could make some good money if you win.”

Allistair had no words, nothing, but he stepped into the middle of the recently cleared floor.

The man stepped up to face him, raising his hands up to the crowd. They cheered for him, the classy hall suddenly becoming rowdy. He then mocked Allistair,

“You have chosen poorly. I am Sir Xavier, knight of the realm.”

Allistair heaved a breath of relief, glad the man was a knight of the realm, not a Knight Avant, and very glad that he wasn’t fighting him with a sword. Sure, Allistair was a fair sword fighter, but not trained to the level of a knight.

Both men removed their shirts, as wrestling didn’t work well with them on. That brought cheers for both Allistair and Xavier from the maidens. Allistair held his fist up to acknowledge their cheers and then faced off with his opponent.

The tavern owner called for bets, betting on Xavier winning and challenging people to bet against him. He gave good enough odds that some people did, even though the knight was favored.

Lina countered by jumping on a bench and calling out, “I’ll give odds that Allistair wins! If he loses, I’ll pay double your bet.”

Most of the people laughed at her and eagerly placed bets. Giving those odds on an unknown contender against a knight seemed certain money. If only she could take all the bets, but she didn’t have the money to cover many.

Almost everyone wanted to bet against Allistair. Sure, he was supposed to be a hero, and he was a tournament champion in Chesterfield, but he was up against a knight of the realm, one who served the kingdom under command of the captain of the guard. Lina took the last bet she could cover, hoping Allistair would win.

Allistair looked around at the large crowd, which was growing as people were coming in off the street to

watch, even the musicians were watching instead of playing. All eyes were fixed on him. What had he agreed to? How stupid was he? His chance of winning was slim. Even worse, with the bets, he could not only not make money, but he could lose money. He glanced over at Lina, whose happy smile and total confidence set his resolve. She had great faith in him, so he had to win for her. He clasped his hands to keep them from quivering and took a deep breath to calm down.

The tavern owner barked for the fight to start. Xavier immediately shot out with a brutal kick to the gut. Allistair blocked, yet even with the block, the blow felt like it cracked a rib. That wasn't surprising with Xavier being a goat crevan. Next, Xavier lunged to grab Allistair to slam him to the hard wooden floor, but Allistair ducked under his arms, then snapped up to deflect a strike with his forearm.

Next, Allistair dove in low, grabbed Xavier around the legs, lifted him off the floor, spun him around, and slammed him down, only for Xavier to hook Allistair's neck as he fell and drag him down with him.

Xavier twisted and locked onto Allistair's leg from underneath. Allistair wrenched his hips, whipped his free leg over to break the hold, and rolled back to his feet.

The two men squared off again. Allistair was already gasping for breath, but his opponent was heaving for air too. The two were well-matched, which meant a close, bloody fight.

They circled around each other, each hunting for an opening. As they did, fast, driving music suddenly rang through the air. The musicians were playing fight music.

Allistair wasn't sure if the rapid tempo was

energizing or distracting. He threw his hands out to try to catch Xavier from coming in with a low headbutt, yet the crevan charged right through. Thinking fast, Allistair twisted and shoved down on the base of Xavier's neck, driving Xavier into the floor, so he couldn't land a clean hit.

The brawl raged on, and first blood was drawn when Xavier rammed Allistair and sent him crashing into a table. Allistair hit hard, slicing his arm open on a jagged nail. Shock flashed through him – his fision swam and warm blood trickled down his forearm – but he forced himself to lock onto the fight, not the sting. He hauled himself up. The parted crowd hemmed him in on all sides, and Xavier was already barreling straight at him.

With a sudden surge of energy, Allistair vaulted onto the table, did a back flip over Xavier, clamped onto his horns from behind, and slammed him face-first to the floor.

The crowd erupted into cheers and jeers, depending on who whey had placed their coin.

For a brutal minute, the two men wrestled on the floor, trading short, heavy punches. At one point, Xavier cranked Allistair into an arm bar. Allistair's joint screamed in protest, yet he muscled through, rolled his weight over, and hammered Xavier in the ribs.

They both scrambled away and staggered to their feet, each looking half-beaten already.

"You're dead," Xavier hissed as he barreled in and swung. Allistair fired back, and the wrestling match degenerated to an all-out slugfest.

Both men staggered with every blow, too battered and breathless to keep their guards up. Who would stay

standing?

“Stay up!” Lina urged. “You’ve got this.”

Allistair could barely see straight, as his head was spinning and throbbing. The pounding music didn’t help, yet, he locked his eyes on Xavier who was charging in for another headbutt. Allistair snagged one horn and unleashed a crushing right punch. With both hands occupied, he couldn’t block Xavier’s counter-punch. Both men staggered, and the entire tavern went dead silent, waiting to see who would drop first.

Xavier crashed down to the floor first, with Allistair collapsing only a second behind him. Fortunately, Allistair landed on his knees right beside Xavier and drove one last punch into his jaw, knocking him unconscious. Then Allistair barely managed to raise a shaking hand and mumble, “I win,” before blacking out himself.

The tavern exploded into noise, and the tavern owner paid out the wagers, grousing the entire time because he’d lost big.

With nothing left for her to do, Lina patted the heavy coin pouch at her hip – every wager she’d taken was hers to keep. She bolted over to Allistair to check on him and immediately began binding his bleeding arm. She then pressed her hand against a crystal on the necklace she always wore and blew on Allistair’s face wounds. Being only part-elf, she couldn’t fully heal, yer her magic stopped the bleeding and pulled him back to consciousness.

The faunen who played the pennywhistle ran over and started healing Allistair, as faunen heal better than elves.

Soothing relief came and the faunen rubbed her hot hands over the wound of both Allistair and Xavier, showing her healing to be much stronger than normal faunen. There were few signs of the fight when she stopped her gentle caress, picked up her penny whistle, and played their headaches away.

“That was a feckin’ incredible way to heal,” Allistair noted as his headache drifted off with the notes. “Thank you. How do you do it?”

“I’m not just faunen,” the faunen explained. “I have a little elf in me too, so I can strengthen my healing with stones.” She pulled back her hair to show pointed ears. She then leaned over and whispered, “I have a little Rhys in me too. Don’t tell people, but that is how I heat my hands up. I can’t do fire.”

Allistair put his hand on her arm. “That was feckin’ amazing! You’re the best healer I’ve ever met. I’m ecstatic you were here.”

“I’m glad too,” she agreed with a soft smile. “I made money betting on you.”

Allistair chuckled, patted her arm, and went over to Lina.

“That was quite the fight,” she noted. “I’m glad there was a better healer than me around.” She gave him a hug and excitedly showed him the money she’d made. “This is great tips. Maybe we should get you in more fights to bet on until your fame spreads.”

Allistair raised an eyebrow. “No, thank you. That feckin’ hurt.”

Lina smiled and elbowed him. “But look at this money.” She then chuckled. “Actually, I think many

ladies would bet on you just because of how you look with your shirt off."

"You are a strange one, beautiful, but strange," Allistair noted. "Traveling with you definitely keeps me entertained."

"I am a minstrel, it's literally my job," Lina shot back, snatching a roll from a bread bowl. She squinted at it for a beat. "Maybe I should learn to juggle." She glanced at the roll. "Better yet, you should. I throw like a girl."

Their light-hearted banter cut off as Xavier stormed over, scowling. He marched straight up to Allistair, shoving Lina aside in the process. "You are going to regret this!" he hissed inches from Allistair's face. "I will have my pride back." Without waiting for a response, he spun on his heels and stalked out the door.

Allistair watched him go and let out a heavy breath. "I seem to have a feckin' talent for making enemies. This is not quite how I pictured my first night in Roifort ending."

"Fair enough," Lina conceded, "but it doesn't have to end on a sour note. The night is still young."

The musicians started playing again, and people started dancing. Allistair watched Lina eagerly watching them and asked, "Would you like to dance?"

Lina's eyes lit up. "I didn't know you danced."

"I didn't say I can," Allistair corrected. "I asked if you wanted to."

Lina raised her shoulders innocently. "And what if I do? Are you going to dance with me?"

Allistair shrugged. “Something akin to dancing,. It may look like a three-legged bear with a hangover, so don’t say I didn’t warn you, but shall we?”

Lina jumped up and held her hand out. “I’d love to. In fact I am very curious now. I’ve never seen a three-legged bear, a bear who dances, or a bear with a hangover. This is going to be gold. Let’s go.”

Allistair took her hand and walked over to the center of the floor. He placed one arm around her waist and clasped her hand with his other. He wasn’t the suavest of dancers. He didn’t glide across the floor with a practiced smolder, yet he knew how to enjoy himself, and carried a steady rhythm, definitely better than a drunk bear.

As they danced, the tempo slowed, so Allistair drew Lina closer.

She looked up into his eyes. He was strong, solid as oak, and there was something deeply secure about being held in his arms. She gave him a soft smile, and he returned it. For a moment, they gazed into each other’s eyes, the noise and crowd of the tavern fading into the background as the entire world vanished into a dream.

That was the perfect way to end the night, just the two of them. Allistair would worry about Xavier in the morning, and probably have to deal with both him and Elliiot, but at the moment, he had a pretty girl in his arms, and nothing else mattered.

Chapter 6: Market, The Great Hall, and an Offer that Couldn't Be Refused

The next day, Lina wanted to see the city, so Allistair brought her to the large, bustling market of Roifort, that dwarfed Chesterfield's market. The shops were all close together, some touching side by side, and goods that could only be imagined in Chesterfield graced tables outside shops.

In the morning, most merchants sold wares outside their shops. There were beautiful brass wine goblets, silver tankards, yards of cloth, tables of food, and skillfully crafted swords. Lina stopped at a table with jewelry.

As she looked at the fancy necklaces, Allistair walked over to a shop that sold swords. He picked one up, and the shopkeeper immediately scolded, "Don't touch that. You aren't a knight or noble."

“I’m not,” Allistair agreed. “I’m a tournament champion in Chesterfield. I know how to use a sword.”

“Only knights and nobles may buy swords,” the shopkeeper scolded. “Put it down.”

“I’m just admiring the steel,” Allistair defended, turning the blade slightly in his grip. “I won’t buy it. A blade like this costs more than the king’s tax collectors leave me in a year, but the craftsman who made it is feckin’ incredible. It’s light enough to be easily maneuverable, and the balance is dead-on.”

“Put it down!” the shopkeeper insisted. “I could get in trouble for letting you pick it up.”

Allistair immediately put the sword back, his brow knitted in genuine confusion. “Why would you get burned for that?”

The man shook his head. “First time in Roifort?”

“Close enough,” Allistair admitted. “I’ve been to Fletcher’s Field several times for tournaments, but that’s southeast of here. I’ve never made it this far into the city. Does it feckin’ show?”

The shopkeeper nodded, then leaned in and warned, “Do not even breathe a word to anyone that you know one end of a sword from the other. Since you aren’t a knight or a noble, you will be assumed to be an outlaw. Keep your head down and don’t upset the knights.”

Allistair stiffened, a wry grimace crossing his mouth. “Well, that ship might have sailed already. I wrestled Sir Xavier last night. He beat me up pretty good too, until I won.”

The shopkeeper’s eyes went big, and he warned, “You should probably leave the city soon. I hear Arwood

is a nice town. I wouldn't be eager to go to Montlier. Duke Korbyn is rumored to be very strict." He looked around, then urged, "Now, go. If you have made enemies with a knight, I don't want you near my shop."

Allistair turned heel and went back over to Lina. She had a crowd around her and was playing her lute and telling a story to the music. That didn't surprise him. After all, Lina was a minstrel, and people always turned to minstrels for news, not that she actually had much, as she didn't travel often, but she definitely had good lore to tell and was entertaining.

Allistair was taking in her performance when Xavier and a very tall Knight Avant with tiger ears strode up. Allistair looked as excited as a little boy who had just caught a lizard at the sight of the Knight Avant, but his joy quickly vanished when they halted in front of him and the Knight Avant insisted, "You are coming with us."

"What the charge?" Allistair challenged, crossing his arms.

"We will speak in private," the Knight Avant replied calmly. "I am Sir Perkin of the Knight Avants. If you do not obey me, I may, by right, cut you down where you stand."

"Easy… I'm coming," Allistair conceded, raising both hands to chest level. "No need for force. May I at least tell my partner where I'm headed?"

Sir Perkin nodded. "She may come. Some entertainment in the keep may be appreciated."

Allistair walked over with the two knights, and the crowd around Lina instantly scattered.

Allistair caught her eye, giving a quick nod toward

the knights as he explained he had to go with them and asked if she wanted to come along.

“Come!” Sir Perkin ordered. “That is not a request.”

Lina blinked, clutching her lute to her chest before shooting Allistair a look that clearly asked what trouble he’d gotten them into.

Perkin and Xavier escorted Lina and Allistair into the guardhouse at the entrance to the keep. Allistair was in awe as he walked up the stairs. He was actually where the Knight Avants stayed. Merely glimpsing their stronghold was a dream.

He and Lina were brought up a flight of stairs to a large room. There were several knights in there, three giants, two gati, a crevan fox, a half-elf, and a rhys, plus about a dozen women of various races. Obviously, they weren’t knights, but they were seeing to the needs of the knights.

A pointed-ear, half-elf, half-giant, standing a few inches taller than Allistair, stood up and stepped over to them. He looked up and down, inspecting Allistair as if he were a sword being considered for purchase. “So, you are the man who beat Xavier in a fight. You do look strong, but I think I’d still beat you in a fight.”

“Likely,” Allistair agreed, his eyes wide, but trying not to let how intimidated he felt show. “What do you want me here for?”

“To invite you to be a Knight Avant,” the elf-giant answered. “Please, have a seat and let me explain.”

Allistair froze. Did the man actually say what he heard? They wanted him as a Knight Avant?

“Sit,” the elf-giant instructed.

Allistair shook his head to clear it and sat by Lina. The elf-giant began, “I am Sir Guilhem, leader of the Knight Avants. I am offering to have you join us.” He straightened up. “Actually, this isn’t a request. I am informing you that you are now a Knight Avant.”

Allistair’s eyes went as wide as a startled owl’s. “Isn’t there a contest to become one? Don’t I have to prove myself?”

Guilhem nodded. “You proved yourself fighting Xavier.” He leaned forward, glanced over at Xavier, and whispered, “You must be made an Avant, or it makes Xavier look weak. We cannot have that happen. The reputation of the knights, even the knights of the realm must be kept up. We can’t have some lowly wrestler who fights in small tournaments beat our knights. Therefore, I am going to give you a title, so Xavier will have been beaten by Sir Allister of the Knight Avants.”

That sounded really good, and Allistair had to hold himself down to not bounce out of his chair as a child being offered a tart. Allistair almost accepted, but looked over at Lina. “What about her? I can’t leave Lina. I’m her bodyguard and partner.”

Guilhem gestured with a large flourish of his hand. “I’m sure I can get her performing in the castle. I have a great deal of sway. Besides, there is always more room for another beautiful maiden. You have quite the lady there.” He then winked at Allistair.

“We aren’t courting,” Allistair corrected. “I perform with her.”

“Right,” Guilhem chuckled in disbelief. “You two are just partners. If that’s your story, that’s what I’ll tell people.” He then leaned over to Lina and offered, “If it’s

true, I could spend an evening at a tavern with you. You'd enjoy it. No woman can resist my charm." He then posed, showing off his muscles.

Lina raised her shoulders and shrank back slightly. "I think I'll pass."

Guilhem raised his eyebrows and quipped to Allistair, "Just partners, right. There's no way she would reject me if you two were truly only partners." He snapped his fingers, and several ladies came over to him and hung on his arms.

Allistair almost made a snippy come back, but considered it not a wise move since he was about to become a knight under Sir Guilhem.

Instead, he stood up and asked, "When do I start?"

Guilhem motioned where knights were training. "Immediately. How well do you sword fight?"

"That's debatable," Allistair admitted. "I don't have a real sword. We use wooden swords in tournaments to not kill our opponents. I've done very little with real swords, and mostly in tournaments I wrestle."

"Then let's get right to training you with a sword," Guilhem instructed. He turned to Sir Perkin and ordered, "Take him out and train him." He paused for a moment, then added, "Don't bloody him up too much."

Sir Perkin scowled more than a tiger who was about to pounce as he hissed, "Come, Allistair. You have a great deal to learn."

Allistair glanced over at Lina before he walked out, her contagious smile making one burst on his face. She believed in him.

Once he left, Sir Guilhem turned to Lina. “We have a little time before the noon meal. I will introduce you to King Didier there. Until then, why don’t we get to know each other better? If you and Allistair really aren’t courting, I think you might be a good addition to my harem.”

“Your harem?” Lina snipped. “Is that legal?”

“Not for peasants,” Guilhem boasted, “but knights and nobles get some special privileges. Besides, I can’t deny women access to my god-like body.”

Lina held her hands up to chest level. “They can have you. I have no desire to be part of a harem.”

Guilhem put his arm around her and suggested, “Better mine than King Didier’s or Counselor Ormondo’s. King Didier is… never mind. I won’t say anything bad about the king, but I will tell you that Ormondo controls him and makes more of the decisions for the kingdom than he does.”

Lina nodded, her hands beginning to tremble. “So, how do I deal with them?”

Guilhemm waved his hand dismissively. “Just entertain them.” He lowered his voice and warned, “Keep them happy. You do not want to be on the bad side of King Didier or his counselors.”

The tremor in Lina’s hands made its way up her arms. Counselor Florence already didn’t like her. Yet, Lina joked, “They’ll be best off not getting on my bad side either.”

“I’m serious,” Guilhem warned, his voice hard and cold. “You don’t know King Didier or Ormondo as I do. Do not cause waves.”

The trembling spread through Lina's entire body, so she picked up her lute and began playing. Guilhem watched her play, which made her a little nervous, as he seemed to be eyeing her as a hungry wolf. Still, the music was calming.

She played until almost noon, when Guilhem came to her and announced, "It is time to go eat. Come. I will present you to King Didier."

Lina went with Sir Guilhem and the other knights to the great hall for their noon meal. The hall was very elaborate with intricate tapestries full of rich, royal colors on the walls and detailed carvings in the woodwork. A row of tables ran along each side of the hall, and table runners ran across them. Golden candlesticks adorned the tables, and fancy brass sconces held candles on the walls.

Lina Looked around, her eyes wide in awe. "This is what I call a stage. I could get use to this, assuming they don't throw me in the dungeon first." She then turned to Guilhem and joked, "If I break a vase, you're taking the blame."

Guilhem didn't laugh, but warned, "Be careful."

Seated in the hall were the Knight Avants who weren't currently on duty and the king and his royal counselors. His two high counselors were Counselor Ormondo and Counselor Florence. Lina had met Counselor Florence at the Pewter Rose when Florence kicked her out but she'd only heard rumors of Ormondo and the king. King Didier was an Elvish man from the House of Thibaut. His two main counselors were Ormondo, from the House of Farrow, and Florence, from the House of Vinet. Whichever house the king was from, the two main counselors were always from the other two

main houses.

Every five years there was a tournament to determine who would be the king. A champion from each of the four noble houses would compete, although the fourth house, Garnier, was never in contention, and they didn't get a counselor if they didn't win, so they stopped even putting in a contestant two decades before. Thus, everyone looked at them as a lesser noble house.

Lina saw the fancy clothing the king and counselors wore and felt very under-dressed. After all, her dress was very plain, very normal for a minstrel, just a plain underdress with a laced up overdress.

She forced a smile on her face as she was led up in front of the king. Guilhem introduced her, and King Didier requested that she sing for him and tell tales.

She began playing her lute and singing as everyone ate. The food looked very good, fancier than she was used to. Hopefully she would get a chance to get some. But first, she had to impress the king, so she sang a perky song and lit the room up with her radiant energy.

After performing several songs, she did end up getting to eat. In fact she was instructed to sit down with the king and his counselors.

"So you are from Chesterfield," King Didier noted. "I have not been there is quite some time. Perhaps it's time to pay a visit."

"Indeed," Counselor Ormondo agreed. He then addressed Lina. "I understand that you told the story of the champion defeating Elliot. That is the man who we just had join the Knight Avants, is it not?"

"That's him," Lina confirmed, nervously fingering

the spiced banquet bread on the plate in front of her.

“He is a troublemaker,” Ormondo continued, his statement rather casual, but his tone dark. “It is good he works for us now.”

Lina took a bite of food to keep herself from saying anything, but something felt wrong, very wrong. She shouldn’t have brought Allistair to Roifort.

Her nervousness turned to inner panic when she saw Allistair enter the room with Sir. Perkin. Blood seeped from a cut across Allistair’s forehead, and his cheek was bruised. Surely, that wasn’t normal training. Something was wrong. Allistair being a Knight Avant and her a performer for the king was not going to be the dream either of them had expected.

Still, she felt somewhat proud as King Didier stood up and addressed Allistair. “You are the new Knight Avant?”

“Yes,” Allistair confirmed, bowing low to him.

“Very well,” King Didier replied. “I will now swear you in and have you take your oath. Take a knee.”

Allistair was excited as he took a knee, as his dream was coming true. Yet, after what he’d seen of Perkin, there was some trepidation. He looked up at the king. Hopefully, he would not regret the oath he was about to make.

Chapter 7: Beasts, Blood, and a Cute Little Girl

Allistair trained for a week with the Knight Avants.

“Your swordmanship is improving,” Sir Perkin noted as Allistair parried a strike during training. “It is obvious that you have trained with a sword, despite commoners not being allowed to.”

Allistair struck back, but Perkin blocked with his shield. Allistair really wasn’t used to fighting with a shield, so it was taking some time to learn.

Allistair struck hard as he defended, “I see no reason why my class shouldn’t be able to defend themselves. Everyone should have a right to self-defense.”

Perkin face turned red with anger, and hecame in with a massive slash. Allistair blocked the strike with his shield, but Perkin flipped his tiger claws out and cut Allistair on the side. “They shouldn’t!” he yelled.

He then stepped back and ordered, “Stop the bleeding and sit!”

Allistair immediately obeyed. The cuts weren't too deep, as they weren't intended to kill, just to teach Allistair a lesson. He sat and put pressure on them.

Perkin had made it quite clear when training started that he could have Allistair whipped if he didn't cooperate, so Allistair never disobeyed.

Perkin lectured, "We don't want the people to have weapons or know how to use them. They are harder to control that way. The noble houses have a vision, a kingdom where all are united and at peace. The best way to do that is to have us control the people. If they can fight, they might. We do not need war among our own cities. We will be the protectors for them."

"But knights are seldom around while someone is being attacked," Allistar countered, his voice low to not anger Perkin. "If we want peace, people need to all be trained to use weapons. If everyone carries a sword, then people will think twice before attacking anyone. After all, a lady with a bodice dagger is safer than one without."

"No lady should have a weapon," Perkin corrected. "No one who is not noble should have any weapon. We do not want rebellions."

Allistair bit his tongue for a moment to not made a snide comment, then in a very controlled tone, suggested, "If you don't want rebellions, earn the people's trust. The king is not always looked highly upon because of the taxes he imposes, but the Knight Avants are admired and revered. I am honored to be one."

"You shouldn't be one," Perkin sneered leaning toward him. "You are a peasant, only here so Sir Xavier could save face. He is a fool, and I do not care about his reputation, only that of the Avants."

“Avants…” Allistair repeated. “I’ve noticed other knights referring to the group as just Avants, not Knight Avants.”

“It’s shorter,” Perkin explained. “Just say Knight Avants in public, but we’d rather be referred to as the Avants than just the knights. There are other types of knights. Be very proper in public, even with our title. Our reputation is important.”

Alistair nodded. “The Avants do have a good reputation. “I’m proud to be one. I’ve dreamed of this.”

“If you want to stay one, do whatever you are ordered,” Perkin warned. “No questions asked. Understood?”

Allistair gulped. “Understood.”

Perkin stood up. “Now, let’s get training again.”

They both readied their swords and attacked.

They were fighting when a loud bell suddenly rang.

“Come!” Perkin ordered. “We are needed.” He immediately ran toward the front of the keep calling to Allistair, “Keep up!”

Allistair ran behind him, trying to keep up, but Perkin was taller and a tiger crevan, so his stride was longer than Allistair’s. “What’s going on?” he called as he neared.

Perkin did not answer, but ran to where a dozen Avants had gathered.

Sir Guilhem was ordering the knights around. He told Sir Perkin to take a group immediately northwest because the watchman at the tower there had lit a firework. Beasts would be attacking the northwestern

villages soon.

“Come!” Perkin ordered Allistair. He waved his hand and the group that was there all followed him, knowing Guilhem would come soon with more men.

Allistair was on his first quest as a Knight Avant, which felt much like waiting for his first wrestling match in his first tournament. He raised up in his saddle so his horse could go faster.

As he galloped to the fight, he could hear his heart pounding. He’d heard beasts existed, but he’d never seen one. Sure, there were wild animals in Chesterfield, but stories were told of beasts in the mountains who were somehow mutated into chimeric abominations and were big, strong, and deadly.

It didn’t take long to figure out what the beasts were like, as they rode up to a farmhouse where a half dozen beast were fighting eight local knights.

Allistair jumped off his horse. He’d played around with jousting some, but not officially, and otherwise had no experience fighting on a horse.

The family huddled inside the farmhouse was under attack by a beast, so Allistair threw himself between them and the monster. Jaws snapped shut on him. If not for his chest plate, the creature would have torn him to shreds.

The beast looked like a gigantic nightmarish cross between a dog and a bear, with matted dark fur and hot breath. Fear shot through Allistair like a well-aimed arrow. Never had he expected to face such a creature. It made grappling with a giant look like child’s play. Yet, he couldn’t freeze. Innocent lives depended on him, so he swallowed his panic and charged back in.

A beast swiped at him with razor sharp claws. Acting on instinct, he caught a thick foreleg and wrenched the monster's weight to roll it over. As it twisted it clamped his jaw onto his shoulder, so drove a heavy first into its snout to force its teeth loose.

He scrambled back to give himself room to draw his sword, and swung mightily at the charging beast.

Using a sword was definitely a better idea than trying to grapple with a beast, but he'd never been in a real life-or-death sword fight before. It was a hundred times more terrifying than he'd imagined. Focus – he had to focus. He'd been in melee combat in tournaments before, so it wasn't the first time that he'd had to keep his cool among chaos. Yet, it was the first time lives depended on his blade.

He risked a glance over at the family. The father was bleeding heavily. Yet, Allistair couldn't break away to help him, or the beast would rip right through them all.

Allistair locked his eyes back the fight, falling into a pattern of cut and parry, simple moves, but very effective. Honestly, he had no idea what moves to use against a beast, as he'd been training against Perkin. It took several strikes of the beast's claws against his blade to get a feel for how to parry them. One strike slipped past him, slicing his elbow. Sharp pain flared up his arm, but he focused on the fight, not the pain, prioritizing staying alive.

A few strikes later, Allistair found his strategy. He was faster than the beast, so he could get an extra strike in and throw the beast off his rhythm. When he did, he was able to cut the beast across the snout. As the beast reared up in pain, Allistair plunged his sword into the

beast's chest. The creature let out a loud, piercing howl as it crashed to the ground, and Perkin rushed over, driving his blade through the beast and finishing it off.

Both Allistair and Perkin ran over to the family. Allistair immediately started to tend to the father's wounds. Perkin, however, simply told the mother that he needed to talk to her.

The mother was hugging her little girl, way too panicked to talk. Trying to have a conversation with her would have been as productive as trying to give directions to a swarm of bees.

"I can't leave!" the mother cried. "He'll die!" She leaned over her husband, trying to help, but not coherent enough to do anything.

"He should live," Allistair assured her. "He's injured, but I think we'll have time to get him to a healer. Do you have an elf or faunen who heals around here?"

"A few," Perkin answered for her. "This village is in the foothills of the mountains the beasts come from, so we have a watchtower and healers. A faunen or elf will be here soon to heal everyone. Now, we have work to do. Go, help the others. I'll take care of them." He pointed to the family.

"But…" Allistair began.

"That is an order," Perkin insisted. "Go!"

Allistair made sure that Perkin was putting pressure on the wound to stop the bleeding before he left, but obeyed, going to see if anyone else needed help.

There wasn't much else for him to do, as the others had been able to outnumber the beasts and kill them without being severely wounded, all except two of the

local knights, who were wounded before the Knight Avants arrived. Fortunately, an elf and two faunen were already there taking care of them. As soon as Allistair told them of the wounded father, one of the faunens flew that direction.

Allistair sat on a log, winded and hurting. One of the faunens came over to him and asked in a very happy voice for the situation, “May I heal you? You seem to need it.”

“Thank you,” Allistair responded, in too much thought to say more. Why had Perkin been so eager to get him to leave? Why hadn’t he come to the aid of the family sooner?”

The faunen placed her hand on his chest. “Is it your first quest as a knight?”

“Does it show?” Allistair quipped back.

The faunen shrugged. “You seem way too nice for a Knight Avant. Perkin is likely telling the family not to tell anyone that the father was wounded.”

Allistair held his tongue to not make the first comment that popped in his head, and simply asked, “Why not?”

The faunen looked around and whispered, “I’ve said too much. Just keep doing what is right. You saved that family today. Perkin wouldn’t have cared if they died. Last time someone died, Perkin and Guilhem reported that the Knight Avants saved everyone and that the man moved to a safer city.”

Allistair clenched his fists. “That’s feckin’ wrong,”

“Calm down,” the faunen whispered, her voice calm and soothing3. “Relax and let me heal you. You were

brave today."

She was still talking to Allistair as Guilhem and his men arrived, way to late to help, but explaining they had to take a detour to fight another beast.

Guilhem walked over to Allistair and the faunen and asked, "What are you talking about?"

"He was brave today," the faunen explained, her voice happy and vapid. "You have chosen your newest Knight Avant well."

Guilhem nodded. "I hope so. I guess we'll see how he does when he gets into harder situations."

Harder situations? That wasn't a good thought. After all, the fight hurt. Allistair looked up at Guilhem. "I still have a great deal to learn. Are we headed back to the castle?"

"Yes," Guilhem confirmed. "We are going back to the castle by way of the Pewter Rose. I think we've all earned a drink."

Allistair's eyes lit up. "Are you buying?"

"The king will," Guilhem answered. "We get more than just money for our work. We get wine and women. That is what is important in life, and I can't deprive the women of my company. They all want me." He became more serious and instructed, "Do not speak of the attack while at the Pewter Rose. You may say we fought beasts, defeated all of them, and no one was hurt. If anyone asks anything else, just say that you aren't allowed to discuss anything yet. After all, there is information that could be dangerous if our enemies knew it."

Allstair furrowed his eyebrows. "Someone was hurt. And why can't I tell about fighting the beast or the family

they were attacking? That will not aid any enemy."

Guilhem stared coldly at him and replied, "You do not know who all the enemies are."

A shiver of fear surged up Allistair's spine. He didn't trust the king, but it seemed there were many dark dealings he knew nothing of.

Chapter 8: A Fish, a Backdoor, and a Really Inaccurate Tale

Allistair didn't want to wake up the next morning, as all of the Knight Avants had stayed up late drinking at the Pewter Rose. Fortunately, Perkin slept in too.

It was after noon when Allistair finally surfaced. He went down to the kitchen to see if there was any food left. A red-headed, gati, scullery maid was scrubbing the floor.

"Sorry to interrupt," Allistair apologized as he stepped in. "I don't mean to dirty the floor." He sat down to take his boots off to not track dirt. As he did, the maiden bowed to him.

"Don't do that," Allistair instructed, waving his hand dismissively. "You don't need to bow to me."

"But you are a Knight Avant," the maiden replied, barely making enough sound for him to hear. "I am too lowly to even speak to you." She went back to scrubbing.

Allistair squatted down to be on her level. “Do you mind if I get some food?”

“I can do it quickly,” the maiden offered. She stood up, definitely able to do anything quickly. After all, she was a gati, and gati had long legs and six fingers. “What do you want?”

“Anything is fine,” Allistair assured her. “I’m not a picky eater.”

The girl darted around the kitchen and within seconds had a plate of fish, bread, and cheese for him. She bowed as she handed it to him and asked, “Would you like some ale to go with that?”

Allistair put his hand on his still aching head. “I think I’ve had enough ale. I still have a headache from too much last night.”

“I’ll get you water,” she offered, and very quickly handed him a full goblet.

He took the plate, pulled up a stool, and sat at a large table that food was prepared on. The maiden went back to scrubbing the floor.

As he ate, he asked her, “What do you think of the Knight Avants?”

She stopped scrubbing and stared at him. “Are you really asking my opinion?”

Allistair shrugged. “Why wouldn’t I?”.

“I’m a scullery maid,” she pointed out. “Nobles give people like me orders. They do not asked for my opinion.”

Allistair gave a definite nod of his head. “I want it. Please, put down your scrub brush and join me for my

meal. Feel free to get yourself something."

"I've eaten," she timidly responded, "but I will sit at the table."

She did sit down, so Allistair asked again, "What do you think of the Knight Avants?"

The maiden's eyes opened wide. "They are incredible. They are strong, brave, and noble. Every maiden loves them." Her eyes turned from him to his food.

Allistair held his trencher out to her. "Do you want some? Are you sure you're not hungry?"

She eyed it with longing in her eyes. "I've eaten. Scullery maids don't get the same food the nobles do. I had some pottage. That fish is smelling divine."

Allistair handed half of the fish to her and offered, "Eat it."

"But I…" she began.

"Eat it," Allistair insisted. "You don't wish to go against what I tell you, do you? If anyone complains, you can tell them to go to… No, say I ordered you to." He scrunched his eyebrows. "I can do that, can't I?"

"You can," the maiden confirmed as she eagerly took a bite. "Most Knight Avants figure that one out very quickly. You seem different." She shrank back timidly. "Am I out of line saying that?"

Allistair ran his fingers through his hair. "No. I'm not really a formal person, and I don't care about titles."

She blushed. "You are not like the other Knight Avants. They are amazing fighters, but they also are quite proud of their status."

“Hang status,” Allistair replied. He ate another bite, then asked, “What do you know of Perkin?”

The maiden suddenly tensed. “Nothing. I know nothing.”

“Really?” Allistair asked, rubbing his chin. “Do you know nothing, or are you just not allowed to say anything… What is your name? I was about to use it and realized I don’t know it.”

“I’m Nakita,” she answered. “And you are?”

“Allistair. I came from Chesterfield.”

Nakita bounced. “Are you the knight the minstrel told stories of?”

Allistair’s eyes went instantly wide. “Minstrel? Have you met a mostly sprite minstrel at the castle?”

“Yes,” Nakita answered. “Do you want to see her?” She leaned over and pried, “Are you in love with her?”

Allistair didn’t answer immediately, so Nakita shrank back and quickly responded, “I am sorry, sir. I have overstepped my bounds?” She then timidly, but eagerly, ate more.

Allistair chuckled. “No.” He took another bite and finished it before asking, “Is there a way I could get into the castle and talk to the sprite minstrel?”

“Of course,” Nakita answered. “You would have to clear it on Guilhem’s end.”

“I’d rather Guilhem not know,” Allistair explained. “I want to be able to talk freely to her.”

“Talk?” Nakita responded with a knowing nod. “I can get you in to see her. Do you want to go now?”

Allistair pointed to his meal. “As soon as I finish my food.” He handed her some cheese, that she eagerly accepted, quickly ate the last few bites of his food, and stood up.

He suddenly noticed that Nakita hadn’t finished scrubbing the floor. “Will you get in trouble if you don’t finish this now?”

Nakita’s face went white, and she nodded timidly. Then she quickly responded, “I’ll take the punishment. I won’t likely get beaten. I’ll probably only have my wages docked.”

Allistair clasped his hands together in frustration. Then he calmed down and offered, “Why don’t I help you with the cleaning, and then we go?”

Nakita looked more stunned than a deer looking at an archer with a nocked arrow pointed at it. “You know how to clean?”

Allistair laughed. “I just became a Knight Avant. I wasn’t a knight before that, just a champion, and I’ve done plenty of cleaning. In Chesterfield, we really don’t worry too much about titles. I’ve scrubbed plenty of floors. My mother and father raised me to know how to work.”

Nakita smilled. “They sound impressive.”

“They raised me right, even when we had next to nothing,” Allistair agreed. “I have a wonderful family.”

He then went to work with her doing her chores. At least a dozen times while they worked she told him that he didn’t have to help but was amazed that he was. All the while, gawking at him as if he was royalty.

When they finished he asked, “Now, can you take me

to see Lina?"

Nakita put the scrub brushes and bucket away. "Yes. Let's go. You have a pretty maiden to see."

She led Allistair to a wing of the king's keep, but instead of going to the guard at the door, she took him around the back and showed him a hidden door.

"What's this for?" Allistair asked.

"It's used by nobility when they don't want to be seen sneaking into the harem's house," Nakita explained. "If anyone sees you go in, he may question your motives, but you will not be stopped."

Allistair raised his eyebrows. Life in the castle was not how he imagined it would be. After all, weren't Knight Avants and nobles supposed to be role models and very proper?

He followed Nakita into the back of the house. There were many women there. It didn't take long to find Lina among them.

She excitedly ran over and threw her arms around him, exclaiming, "I'm so glad you survived fighting the beasts. I'm going to go sing the tale at the Pewter Rose tonight about the beast attack. I'd love for you to come."

Allistair smiled and teased, "So, I made a song?"

Lina cocked her head. "No. Didn't Sir Perkin kill the beast who was attacking the family and the other Avants kill the other beasts? I was concerned that since you weren't mentioned in the story I heard that you had been wounded."

Allistair stiffened. "No. I actually saved the family. What were you told?"

“I can sing the tale I was told to tell,” Lina suggested. “Would you like to hear it?”

Allistair placed his hand on her arm. “Yes, but first, I want to know if you are all right. It seems you’ve been made part of a harem.”

“Yes,” Lina answered with a bit of a content smirk, “but I made sure that King Didier and anyone else high up doesn’t see me as more than a minstrel.”

Allistair eyed her curiously. “How? Do I want to know?”

She chuckled as she explained, “I told King Didier how handsome he is and how excited I was about being in his harem, and not to worry because the disease that runs in my family that kills everyone young isn’t always contagious. I told him there was an entire ten percent chance he wouldn’t catch it from me.”

Allistair laughed out loud. “That sounds like you. You are creative. Now, that I know you are safe, let me hear the tale.”

Lina picked up her lute and began singing,

“The day turned dark. The knights were called,
to save a town, ransacked,
By mighty beasts with claws and teeth, who
charged in and attacked.
Then came the Knight Avants with speed. They
came to save the night,
And fought with courage, strong and brave.
They charged into the fight.
The local knights, outnumbered by the beasts,
they could not win,
‘Til Perkin led the Knight Avants to fight with
discipline.

Sir Perkin saw a beast approach a child, so small and weak,
Who could not fight the beast off, so her outlook seemed quite bleak.
Sir Perkin fought the beast. It's true. He thrust the killing blow.
He saved her and her family, and asked no quid pro quo.
This tale will be a legend told for years to come and more,
As Perkin's deeds are strong and brave, so worthy of folklore."

She picked up the tempo and added some pep as she sang,

"Now, laud the Knight Avants, the men we've all grown to adore.
They're virtuous and noble. Sin and evil they've forsworn.
So, dance and sing their praises loud. Huzzah for Knight Avants.
They keep you safe and keep the peace, all efforts at detente."

"Detente?" Allistair asked. "I thought I had a large vocabulary."

"The easing of hostilities, mostly between nations," she explained. "There are few words that rhyme with Avant." She shrugged. "Besides, I was told what tale to sing. The court jester actually wrote it."

Allistair furrowed his eyebrows. "Who is the court jester?"

"Jean-Paul," Lina explained. "He's a very good

jester, quite funny. You'd like him. Perhaps you will meet him. He tells me that he is often told what goes into tales and what does not. Apparently, King Didier and his counselors like to control what people get to hear. They definitely want the reputation of the Knight Avants to stay spotless."

"Maybe I've put them on a taller pedestal than they've earned," Allistair grumbled. "Still, I may be able to do some real good from inside the ranks now."

"Hopefully," Lina agreed. "I am learning a great deal that I did not know about our kingdom. I would like to hear more of the different houses. I think much of what we have heard about them is pure nonsense."

"The song you sang definitely was," Allistair scoffed. "I'm the one who saw the beast mauling the family. The father was very bleeding out. I jumped in and saved him. Got my shoulder chewed up, my elbow sliced open, and more bruises than I can count. Trust me; I was a wreck. I'm the one who stabbed the beast. Perkin didn't even show up until the beast had already fallen to the ground. He thrust his sword in at that time, but the beast was already dying. He did nothing. He stopped me from helping the father and threw me out."

"Classic, stealing the glory for himself," A mischievous grin spread across her face. "Perhaps I should rewrite the song."

"No," Allistair warned. "That may land you straight in a cell."

She shot him an expression of more disbelief than a child who had just opened a present to find rocks in it. "Since when are you afraid to stir up trouble?"

"I'm not afraid," Allistair defended. "I just think we

need all the facts first. We can't spread the truth until we know it."

"Fair enough," Lina conceded. "Perhaps we need to see what is really going on. We start with learning what we can of the king, his counselors, and the Knight Avants."

"You have a much better shot at getting close to the king than I do," Allistair remarked.

Lina flashed him a bright grin. "I plan on performing for him, but I think you need to sing with me. I don't see why you can't be a Knight Avant and still be my partner on occasion."

"I do," Allistair countered. "I train most of the day, and I am constantly on alert, having to leave at a moment's notice if there is trouble."

"But I'd really like your help," Lina confessed, tilting her head with a playful smirk. "You can't turn me down. You know it."

"I want to help," Allistair assured her. "I'll see what I can pull off. Let me know when we can sing for the king, and I'll make every effort I can to sing with you. Hopefully, we can do it in a way to make the Avants look better, or I'll be banned from performing with you again." He placed a steady hand on her shoulder. "I'll try, but no promises. The Avants are participating in a tournament soon. Next year is a tournament for the crown, so there will be many tournaments this year. Many from the houses want to practice by fighting the knights. All three houses want to rule for the next five years. Something tells me I'm in for a wild ride."

"Who knows? Maybe you'll win the tournament," Lina teased. "Now, that would be ironic."

Allistair shook his head. “It would be feckin’ glorious, but Perkin would likely be angrier than a wet mountain cat. Fortunately, I don’t really need to win, just make a good showing for the knights.”

Lina strummed a chord on her lute. “The tournament may be a good place to get information.”

“True,” Allistair agreed, “but it also is likely to be a good place to make enemies.”

Chapter 9: A Meeting, a Secret Plot, and Cooked Herring

King Didier, a handsome elf with silver hair, sat with his counselors, Ormando and Florence. Jareth, the keeper of the dungeon, joined them. Ormando was the counselor from the House of Farrow, who lived in the city of Montlier. He was a crevan with fox ears and a tail. His face looked unusually fox-like, as it had coloring that looked as if he might have hair all over. Likely he had some giant in him too, as he was fairly tall. Florence was a gati, who dressed to show off her long legs and curvy figure. That, along with her long blond hair made her look irresistible, and she knew it. Jareth was a rhys, so he had reddish skin and black horns. He was wrapped in a long cloak.

“The crown tournament is coming up next year,” Ormando reminded Didier. “Does the House of Thibaut have a contender for the throne? Are you going to fight?”

“I don’t know yet,” Didier answered.

Ormando smiled. “If you don’t, who will be competing from your house?”

“I’m not sure yet,” Didier repeated. “Duchess Edmee has not made a final decision. Perhaps Sinclair will fight for the crown. Who is going to compete from the House of Farrow? Jacqueline is not a fighter. She cannot compete against knights.”

“Perhaps one of the knights of our realm will,” Ormondo suggested.

“There is rumor Duke Korbyn is thinking of fighting himself,” Didier noted. “Is he hoping to win and then having Jacqueline lead Montlier? She would be next in line in the house of Farrow.”

“Perhaps,” Ormando answered. “I do not know.” He then turned to Florence and asked, “Who will be fighting for the House of Tamur?”

Florence threw her hands up. “I don’t know yet, and if I did, I wouldn’t tell you. I don’t trust you. I know that we all need to be trusting. I try very hard to build relationships so we all are close, but trust takes time. I just hope that whoever becomes king is very handsome and I can keep influence. I also hope that...”

“Wooing a handsome king is the only way you have any influence,” Ormando snipped.

“Enough!” Jareth scolded.

“I’m not done,” Florence insisted. “I think we need to change the rules so the house of Garnier isn’t even allowed to compete. Duke Thayer has many faunen in his city. He could pick a champion who can fly to compete. That would be a huge advantage. None of us want Thayer

as king. He'd be hard to work with, so we just shouldn't allow the house of Garnier to compete."

"I know Duchess Edmee hates Thayer," King Didier added. "I'm not sure why, but I know my house would support that. Yet, as king, I don't know that it's right to change the rules to the crown tournament. After all, it's been being fought as it has for a hundred years. It is a good system. Having a competition every five years and limiting a king to ten years is wise. The rule that if the king dies that his house replaces him is also wise. Having counselors from the other houses is wise too. Honestly, I think it might be good to have a counselor from the house of Garnier."

"That's ridiculous," Florence countered. "The city of Bellemar is too far away to know what is best for the kingdom, and Duke Thayer is so misinformed. Do you know that he thinks royalty should work? He doesn't believe in taxing his people more than to pay his knights. The city of Bellemar and House of Garnier don't even pay all the taxes the other cities do."

"They don't get representation either," Didier noted. "They don't get a counselor to the king. Honestly, it might be good if they did. Duke Thayer's city runs smoothly."

"Because he has it under control," Florence countered. "We need to get the entire kingdom under control, and he will not work with us. He either needs to pay full taxes or have the House of Garnier lose their right to compete in the crown tournament."

"I'll consider it," Didier assured her. "I can see your point, but I don't feel good about changing the rules. Perhaps we can come to some compromise."

“It doesn’t much matter if they compete,” Ormondo argued. “They don’t ever take it seriously enough to win, and their city is made of courtites and faunen. They can’t win. Personally, I think we ought to force them to pay their fair share of taxes. Their city does well. They could afford it.” He looked over at Jareth and asked, “What do you think?”

Jareth laughed. “The house of Garnier is irrelevant and no threat. All of you are wasting time worrying about insignificant things. We need to worry about the beast attacks.”

“What can we possibly do except have the knights fight the beasts?” Didier asked.

“Perhaps nothing,” Jareth answered. Then he added, “Perhaps a great deal. We do not know where the beasts are coming from. Honestly, I suspect foul play. I think magic is involved, likely magic from over the mountains.”

“Magic!” Didier gasped. “Do you really think there is strong enough magic left to mutate beasts? Magic was destroyed years ago. Don’t only remnants remain far north of the mountains?”

“As far as we know,” Jareth responded. “Perhaps the beasts have made their way from the north, but it seems suspicious that they come from from the mountains north and west of Roifort. I think something suspicious is going on in Lamagi, likely dark magic. We need to deal with Lamagi. They are likely somehow mutating the animals. We need to be ready in case they attack. Perhaps we should attack first. Personally, I think we need to send an ambassador to find out what is going on there. Since Ormondo and Florence are needed here, I could go.”

“I could go,” Florence offered. “I really don’t do that much here. Besides, the men on the other side of the mountain may be very strong and handsome.”

“Or perhaps green and scaly,” Jareth pointed out.

Florence instantly stiffened. “Perhaps you should go first.”

“I think we need to prepare for war,” Ormondo advised. “Perhaps we should attack first.”

Didlier contemplated the situation for a moment, and finally decided, “I don’t know. Perhaps we should, but war costs so many lives, and we have no proof Lamagi has anything to do with the beasts.”

“Perhaps we should send in some Knight Avants to infiltrate and kill their leaders so we can take over,” Ormondo suggested. “We must do what it takes to protect our people at all cost.”

“Perhaps,” Didier agreed. “The people’s safety must come first.” He tapped the table they were sitting around. “It could start a war, and I don’t want innocent people hurt.”

Ormondo leaned forward, rolling his hand as if urging Didlier to make a connection. “It’s why we need to fight in their land.”

“I could go as an ambassador,” Jareth again offered. “We also need to address the condition of the Rhys. My people need more help. The city of Varoux is run down and crime is high.”

“Aren’t we giving them tax money to help them out?” Didier asked. “What more can we do?”

“They need representation instead of the House of

Garnier," Jareth suggested. "I am not an official counselor, and my people get no contestant in the crown tournament."

"Varoux doesn't," Didier confirmed. "Yet, neither do Chesterfield or Roifort. Our largest city doesn't even get a contestant because no noble house lives here. That is how the balance of power was designed for our kingdom. That is how it is."

"Then at least make me an official counselor," Jareth insisted. "My people need more."

"Your people have fertile land," Didier noted. "They should not need more than we give them."

"It's not enough," Jareth argued. "My people need more power. We are looked down on by others. We want more power."

Florence perked up. "We could require people to hire Rhys. It is a shame that people are afraid of Rhys, just because all of you have horns and can create fire. Why should people be afraid?" She flipped her hair. "I'm not. Rhys can't catch me, as gati run quickly. The rhys aren't all evil. They may look demonic, but I find it rather attractive. I've been close to a few."

"Not everyone can run away like you," Didier pointed out. "You are a gati, your long legs and quick speed really help you. Your extra thumbs help break a grip too. Other races don't have that."

Jareth leaned over the table, his voice loud and angry. "Just because Rhys are more powerful than other races does not mean we should be shunned. King Didier, you need to help us more, or we will do whatever it takes to have our voices heard."

“Rhys should be helped,” Florence concluded. “I’m just not sure what to do. We need to pressure people to give them more jobs and pay them better.”

“I agree,” Ormondo stated. “We have four priorities right now: helping the rhys, countering the beasts, dealing with Lamagi, and getting everything ready for the crown tournament next year.”

Didier thought for a few moments and suggested, “The knights are dealing with the beasts very well. Perhaps we should hire more. I understand our newest recruit is doing very well. The minstrel has sung tales of him to me.”

“She cannot be trusted,” Ormondo warned. “He was her partner.”

King Didlier raised his eyebrows. “He still is impressive.”

“Not more knights,” Ormondo countered. “More soldiers. If we have too many knights, they will lose their status. We don’t want them common, particularly Knight Avants.”

“Then let’s hire more knights of the realm,” Didier suggested. “That isn’t as high of a status as Knight Avants. Now, we need to deal with the upcoming tournament. It should be exciting. We also need to make sure all the extra taxes are collected from the towns and villages. The people aren’t happy about them. Are you sure it’s a good idea to raise their taxes?”

“It’s necessary,” Ormondo assured him. “After all, it is necessary to take from those who have plenty to help the people who are in need and to protect our kingdom from attack. We fear Lamagi is sending the beasts and preparing for war. We must too.”

“If we must, we must,” Didier conceded. “Now, let’s go to dinner. We can meet again tomorrow.”

They all left, but right after they did, Ormondo and Jareth stepped aside.

“Be careful talking of the beasts,” Ormondo scolded Jareth. “What if Didier figures out that you are the one mutating the animals? You know that if it is found out that you are a wizard that you will be killed, or at least banished.”

“Didier will not find out, and he will do nothing,” Jareth scoffed. “He is too indecisive and very prone to compromise. If he finds out I am a wizard, I will convince him that it is a sacrifice I make for the people and he will struggle with the idea and do nothing.”

“Perhaps,” Ormondo replied, “but we don’t want him getting in the way of starting a war with Lamagi. We could use their resources, and war is a great way to get power. People will give up their freedom to get protection when they feel they are in danger.”

“True,” Jareth conceded. “Yet, I don’t know we need to go to war with Lamagi. Right now, let me deal with them, and we can have a great deal of control without war. We must be patient. For now, we make deals with Lamagi. When the time comes, we can take them over and the war will be easy.”

Ormondo smiled a wry smile. “I want to subject Lamagi to us, better yet, to me. I think you create more beasts and have them attack enough so people die in numbers. Then we blame the beasts on Lamagi and go to war.”

Jareth smiled back. “I can create beasts as quickly as we can capture the animals. Honestly, I make deal with

Lamagi often to get the wild animals. They are more prolific over the mountain."

Ormondo thought for a moment. "This is one of the reasons we need to rule Lamagi. The animals are of use to you, but their resources would be of use to me. They are rich in jewels and ore.

"Patience," Jareth urged.

Ormondo heaved a sigh. "We will discuss it more, but right now, we need to go to dinner. After all, we don't want to cast suspicion on ourselves."

"Of course not," Jareth replied. "No one suspects there is a wizard in the castle. No one suspects anything. Now, let's eat. I hear they are having herring today."

Chapter 10: Another fight, a Truthful Song, and a Round of Ale

Only two days later, Allistair rode out with the Knight Avants to fight beasts again. This time, the attack struck the village just west of the castle. Allistair wondered how beasts had slipped that far east of the mountains without being spotted by a single sentry. Something foul was afoot.

Allistair didn't have time to dwell on it. There were beasts to slay, many of them. It took the Knight Avants reached the village in record time, but already the beasts were rampaging through the streets and had killed several villagers. There were about four dozen Knight Avants in total. Some were away on quests across the kingdom, and some were to never leave the castle unless escorting the king. That meant that only barely three dozen Knight Avants rode into the fray.

There were over a dozen beasts tearing through the

town, and scores of people to protect, so the knights had a brutal fight on their hands. Sir Guilhem ordered the knights to different areas of the village, and once again, Allistair found himself under Perkin's command. Allistair and two other knights ran in to attack a beast that was clawing what appeared to be the lifeless body of a man.

"Help him!" Allistair called to one of the knights. "I'll fight!" It was a bold offer, and he wasn't sure he could win without the help of both knights, but if the man was going to live, he'd need help immediately.

The beast Allistair was fighting appeared to be a monstrous cross between a boar and a moose. It sported curved, ivory tusks, broad antlers, and sharp, jagged teeth. Plus, it was the size of a moose and boar put together, likely weighing twelve hundred pounds.

Allistair wasn't used to fighting against tusks and antlers, but he was improving with his sword. Of course, a bow would do better, as the creature so massive wouldn't be easy to fight up close. Perhaps he'd train with a bow later. Right then, he had to worry about staying alive.

The beast was every bit as nasty and aggressive as a wild moose and boar rolled into one. Allistair knew he couldn't charge in head on. When he first tried, a tusk pierce his armor and gashed his arm. He'd have to fight smart. He leapt back as the beast struck at the other knight and slammed his sword into its sheath.

"What are you doing?" the knight helping the wounded man called out.

Allistair didn't waste breath answering. When the beast lowered his antlers to charge, Allistair vaulted over

its head and clamped onto them. As the beasts reared up with a furious bellow, Allistair swung around to its back, gripped the antlers with his left hand, drew his sword with his right, and drove his blade deep into the back of the creature's neck.

The beast howled in pain and began flailing around, bucking to try to fling Allistair off. Allistair locked his knees and hung on for dear life. The second he found an opening, he plunged his blade into the beast again, and the knight below seized the opportunity to stab the beast in the chest.

The massive creature crashed to the ground, and Allistair had to jump off to keep the beast from falling on him. He hit the ground hard and rolled to absorb the impact. Still, he'd feel the bruises the next day. Scrambling back to his feet, he sprinted to the knight who was helping the injured man.

"Will he live?" Allistair panicked.

The knight shook his head. "He's already dead."

"Why don't we bring healers with us?" Allistair complained, his frustration boiling over. "We always have to wait for local healers to show up."

"Guilhem and Perkin insist it is too dangerous for them," the knight explained. "Come on. We need to go help finish the fight."

Allistair charged off to join the fray against the next beast. As he ran over, he saw Perkin block a strike against a fellow knight instead of protecting a lady. The lady was stabbed with antlers and fell bleeding to the ground. Allistair ran to the lady to stop the bleeding.

"Get up and fight!" Perkin barked.

Allistair looked at the lady bleeding beside him. He couldn't leave her. She'd die for certain. He glance over at the remaining beasts. The knights had the battle under control, so he stayed with the lady, putting pressure on the wound to stop the bleeding until a villager came and took over.

Only then did Allistair spring up and charge into the fray. As he fought, he noticed Perkin deliberately stepping aside and letting a beast slip past him. The beast barreled straight toward a hut. There was likely a family hiding in inside. In fact, a second later, terrified screams pierced the air from behind the shutters. Likely, the people inside saw the beast charging through the window.

Allistair sprinted toward the creature, striking at its hind quarters to turn it's attention from the cottage and to him. "Help!" he shouted to Perkin, but Perkin did not come.

Another knight dashed over to back him up. Allistair was grateful for the help, as he was exhausted, bruised, and bleeding. Yet, he pushed through. He couldn't let innocent people die. He raised his shield to catch snapping teeth and slashed at the creature's flank, while the other knight darted in low to drive his blade into the beast's chest. It didn't take long before they had defeated the beast. Allistair let out a ragged sigh of relief, knowing he couldn't have lasted much longer. The knight fighting beside him, dropped to his knees, gasping for air.

Allistair sheathed his sword for a moment, buried his face in his hands, and muttered, "I need water." If only he had some. He turned around slowly to see if anyone else needed aid. Fortunately, the last of the beasts were also dead, but bodies of slain villagers littered the ground.

Perkin strode up to Allistair, obviously furious, yet, keeping is expression tight with the crowd around, and hissed in a low, venomous tone, “What did you just do? You broke ranks and defied my orders!”

“There are people in that cottage,” Allistair defended. “They needed protection.”

“No,” Perkin snapped. “You need to learn to obey orders. I had strict orders not to protect that house. The family who lives there speak against the king.”

“There is no law against speaking your mind,” Allistair retorted, “and there feckin’ shouldn’t be.”

“They breed unrest,” Perkin hissed. “Do not question. It is not our job to decide who are traitors and who are not. It is our job to follow orders.”

Allistair clenched his jaw shut so hard that his teeth ached. Fighting the twelve hundred pound beast was easier than holding his tongue. He said nothing, but turned and stormed off.

He hadn’t gone far when a ten-year-old boy and a maiden who looked about sixteen ran from the house. The maiden ran up and hugged him, thanking him for not letting the beast get to them.

Allistair pointed to the house. “Who else is in there?”

“Our parents,” the boy answered. “That’s all.”

Allistair stared at the house for a long moment. Was the father really a traitor? From where Allistair stood, the Knight Avants weren’t anything close to what their gleaming reputation made them out to be. He dragged his hand over his face and rubbed his throbbing temples. Was he thinking straight? He’d gone toe-to-toe with a massive beast. Maybe he was hearing wrong. Maybe he was

hallucinating from fatigue. No… no, he wasn't. His head was clear enough, and his gut didn't lie. What was going on? Something in the kingdom was rotten – rotten to the core.

"You are a hero!" the maiden assured him, keeping her arms around him. "I am in your debt."

"It's my job," Allistair responded. "Glad I could help."

She was going to say more to him, but Perkin ordered, "Allistair, help clean up this mess!"

Allistair swallowed his anger, followed orders and went immediately to help clean up the aftermath. While he hauled wreckage and tended to the shaken villagers, he was able to help villagers in need, but his mind was miles away, churning over what he'd just witnessed. The system was rigged, entirely rotten. Good people had needlessly died. Why weren't villages given steel and taught to defend themselves against beasts? Even worse, why were some of the villagers purposely not protected, left to be devoured by beasts? His hunger for answers burned like acid in his gut, but even asking the questions was forbidden.

Allistair was ecstatic when the Knight Avants were called to return to the guardhouse. Sure, he had many questions left unanswered, but staying around wouldn't answer them, so he mounted his horse and joined the other Avants.

They didn't go straight to the guardhouse, as they all stopped at the Pewter Rose.

Sir Guilhem bought ale for all of them. Allistair was happy to accept the drink. He was even happier when he saw that Lina was there. She was singing and telling

stories.

As soon as she set eyes on him, she finished the song she was singing, ran over to him, threw her arms around him, and exclaimed, “I’m so happy you survived! I can’t wait to hear the tale.” She then saw the bruises on his face. “Are you all right? Do you need healing?”

“This is after healing,” Allistair admitted. “Faunen can’t heal everything.”

Lina put her hand on his bruised cheek. Then she held onto the stone on her necklace and blew in his face. It did help, but she could only do so much as the faunen had healed most of what could be healed. She gently rubbed his cheek with her hand. “I wish I could heal you more. I’m only about a fourth elf, so I don’t heal very well. I do better with people I care about.” Her tone instantly changed, and she snipped, “That’s not very many people.”

“Sometimes I’d like to hear your story,” Allistair prodded.

“I’m sure you would,” Lina quipped. “Get used to disappointment. I don’t tell of my past. Now, this is a celebration of the knights’ victory. Let’s go sing.”

Allistair agreed and added, “I’m glad there hasn’t been time for the story of our fight with the beasts to be rewritten yet. Perkin wanted me to let a beast attack a family in a house. I fought the beast anyway.”

Lina leaned in close and whispered, “I have learned a few things while singing for King Didier. There is a great deal of corruption. The king, well… mostly his counselors, wanted there to be many dead in the last attack. They are trying to rile the people up to anger, making them think the kingdom of Lamagi is sending the

beasts, so they can get support for starting a war."

Allistair clenched his fists. "That's feckin' evil. Obviously, the extra taxes and not allowing the common people to have swords so they can defend themselves from beasts or attacks by thugs. That's wrong, but I had no idea there was as much corruption as there is. What feckin' brilliant thing can we do?"

Lina smiled a soft smile at him and suggested, "Let's sing."

Allistair took a quick drink from his mug before they went to the front of the room. It was crowded, as there were not just the knights there.

"What are we going to sing?" Allistair asked.

"Not sure yet," Lina answered. "I may make it up as I go."

"I really like getting to work on songs and get the words right," Allistair reminded him.

Lina urged him to step forward. "There's not time right now. Let's just sing."

She began singing:

"The Knight Avants fought long and hard 'gainst vicious enemies!
They followed orders, as they had been given firm decrees."

Allistair sang the next line.

"Though innocents were saved there still were many men who died.
Perhaps it's time to arm the men to fight where they reside."

Lina then sang,:

"It's not the weapons that cause harm, but men
who wield for might.
A weapon in the hands of good is always used
for right."

Allistair boldly sang out:

"They say that power doth corrupt. They're wise
and truthful words.
To think that knights can't turn corrupt is naive
and absurd."

Lina stepped in front of him, stealing the stage, for her next line:

"So stay the course and fight for right. If not,
then evil wins.
Without strong heroes, all hope's lost, and life
becomes chagrin."

Allistair noticed Perkin glaring at him, so he spun Lina around and added,

"But now's the time to celebrate a vict'ry for
folktales.
Let's have some fun. Let's dance and sing, and
have a round of ale!"

He then called over to Perkin, "How about it? Is the king buying? Is this victory worth another round?"

"Indeed," Perkin replied to the cheers of the knights, who all excitedly went to get their mugs filled.

As they did, Perkin walked over to Allistair and

warned, “There will be no more talk of arming peasants. Do you understand?”

Allistair met his eyes with a firm conviction. “It would have saved lives today. We can’t get to attacks fast enough, and in the time it takes for us to arrive, many people can die.”

“That is not important,” Perkin replied, his tone colder than the depths of a deep, dark cave. “If the peasantry is armed, what is to keep them from revolting?”

“Morals,” Allistair answered, not backing down. “Knowledge. Truth. Good people don’t revolt if not under tyrants. Weapons in the hands of good people keep the peace.”

“I know,” Perkin admitted with an unusual hint of pain. “That is what we are afraid of.” He looked around before whispering, “If there is peace, if the people can defend themselves, then the Avants have little to no power.”

“So?” Allistair quipped, giving a careless shrug like a boy who’d just been scolded for tracking mud across the floor. “I’m not interested in power.”

“We need to keep power,” Perkin insisted, stepping closer. “If the Avants lose control, this land will spiral into chaos. You have no idea how fragile our realm is. Freedom is dangerous. Less freedom is the only way to keep the people safe.”

Allistair pressed his lips into a thin line for a moment, biting back every word that would earn his a flogging. “Understood,” was all he let escape his mouth. He then turned, caught Lina’s hand, and strode off with her. As soon as he was out of earshot of Perkin, he whispered, “We need to figure out what is actually going

on with our feckless leaders, and we need to expose the whole thing."

"They may just be evil, not feckless," Lina corrected, shooting a glance back over her shoulder. She gave a sharp shrug. "Then again, the king definitely fits the bill."

Allistair's voice was low and gritty. "The system isn't what we are told. It's all a big show 'cause they don't want people knowing the truth. It's broken. We can't trust a word our leaders say."

Lina shook her head, a wry half-smile tugging at her mouth. "I know you well enough to know you are going to make enemies, and people in high places will see you as a problem.

Allistair looked her dead in the eyes, his resolve hardening like forged iron. "I'm proud to be a problem."

Chapter 11: Captives, Fire, and an Intimidating Duke

Allistair struck at Sir Perkin, but Perkin parried and hit back, hard, sending Allistair staggering back. After all, being over seven feet tall, Perkin packed a punch.

“Stop,” Perkin ordered. “Our lesson is over now. You’re improving, but your sweep, riposte is still a beat late, which makes it easy to block. You need to keep practicing it.”

Allistair furrowed his eyebrows. “If I need to keep practicing it, why are we cutting practice short? Generally, we go another half hour.”

“We have a job to do,” Perkin replied. “Sir Guilhem has ordered me to take a handful of men to escort travelers to Montlier.”

“Never been to Montlier,” Allistair quipped. “Sounds like an adventure.”

“Just do as you are told,” Perkin warned. “Don’t ask questions, and remember that you’re under an oath of

loyalty."

Allistair blinked, looked as confused as if a maiden had just asked him for advice and replied, "Of course I will be loyal,"

"You will," Perkin insisted, his tone as cold and piercing as icicles. "If you aren't, I will have you flogged."

Allistair's eyes went wide. Flogged? Was he serious? Judging by the cold glare in Perkin's eyes, he definitely was.

Perkin ordered him to grab his pack and meet him at the stables.

That didn't take long. After all, every Knight Avant had to be ready to go on a moment's notice. The fact that Perkins had told him to grab his pack meant it was going to be a trip that would take at least a week.

He wished Perkin had given him a little more time. If he'd had even a half hour notice, he could go say good-bye to Lina. His thoughts drifted to her as he hurried out of the knight's tower. There was something very special about Lina. She was spunky, sharp, kind, and absolutely gorgeous with whatever coloring she gave herself.

When Alllistair reached the stables, three wagons packed with people waited with a guard perched on each driver's bench.

Perkin strode up to Allistair with another knight beside him. Allistair knew the knight, Sir Camden. He was a few years older than Allistair and lethal with a blade. They had sparred a few times, and talked at dinner before.

Allistair was directed to climb onto the front bench

of a wagon beside one of the guards. He hopped up and immediately glanced back, taking in the people behind him. They wore ragged clothes and looked worn down. He started to ask, “What are you…”

“Quiet!” the guard snapped. “We are ordered to take them to Montlier, not talk to them.”

That set off alarms. “Seriously?” Allistair challenged. “It doesn’t hurt to…”.

“We are not to speak to them,” the guard insisted. “We are to take them to Montlier. They must stay silent the entire trip. We are riding past the Freedom Faction command post. We cannot draw attention to ourselves, or they might attack.”

“The Freedom Faction?” Allistair echoed. “What’s the Freedom Faction and why would they attack?”

“Just follow orders,” the guard barked.

Allistair turned back to the people in the wagon. They were all sitting rigidly, looking terrified. For the first time, he noticed that they all had their hands tied.

That wasn’t right. Something was rotten. Every muscle in Allistair’s body tensed, gripped by the cold certainty that something dark was unfolding right in front of him. He leaned over the seat back and dropped his voice. “What’s going on?”

All the people in the wagon stared at him as if he was a vicious, starving monster.

“I’m not going to hurt you,” he assured them softly. “I just want to know why you’re tied?”

No one breathed a word until a boy, no older than ten, started to say something. The adults around him

immediately quieted him.

“What’s going on?” Allistair demanded, raising his voice enough for anyone nearby to hear. “I want to know what I’m involved in here.”

“Just follow orders,” Perkin growled, marching over to him. “Everyone is to make this trip in silence, and we must make it look like these people are prisoners to keep the Freedom Faction from trying to rob them.”

Allistair shook his head for a moment, barely believing what he was hearing. Did he hear right? He knew Perkin wasn’t likely to give him a straight answer, but he still blurted out, “Why can’t anyone speak? Why would them looking like prisoners help? Wouldn’t a group called the Freedom Faction actually try to free people? And why don’t these people have any feckin’ belongings with them? I want to know what is going on. Tell me!”

“You cannot make demands of me. I outrank you,” Perkin snarled with his eyes glaring hard enough to burn through Allistair. “The Freedom Faction is not about freeing people. They are not what they claim to be. Now, no more questions. Just obey orders, or I will have you flogged. Truth be told, I’d love an excuse.”

Allistair didn’t doubt that for a second. A dozen biting comebacks flashed through his mind, but he didn’t think it wise to upset Perkin more, so he sat silently as a wagon full of guards rode up and all the convoy rode out. The entire way, he wondered what was really going on. If only he could speak with the people.

They rode for hours in heavy silence. With every passing mile, Allistair’s hunger for answers grew sharper, yet, none of the tied travelers would speak. They were

allowed out of the wagons when breaks were taken to water the horses, but the people's hands were not untied. Still, nobody uttered a sound, but Allistair caught silent tears rolling down several faces.

He watched for an opening to slip beside one of the captives. Obviously, they were, but surely they weren't criminals.

They were of all races. There were quite a few rhys and many from a race he wasn't familiar with, who all had orange to red hair, were on the short side, and seemed fairly strong.

He walked over to the boy who tried to talk before and whispered, "You can't speak to me?"

"No," the boy whispered back.

"Where are they taking you?" Allistair again whispered, focusing his eyes on the horses, so no one could tell he was trying to speak with the boy, though every instinct screamed to him to cut the boy's ropes and shield him.

A lady stepped over between the boy and Allistair and warned the boy, "Don't say anything, or we will both be killed."

"I'm scared," the boy cried.

The lady put her arms around the boy as best as she could with her wrists tied together.

Allistair desperately wanted to say something else, to uncover what had the people so afraid, but Perkin called over, "Silence, Allistair! Get over here."

Allistair obeyed. As soon as he stepped up to Perkin, he demanded, "What's going on?"

Perkin pointed to a large building at the base of the mountain. “That is the Freedom Faction. Stay quiet!”

Stay quiet… with so many questions? If only Allistair could get answers, but obviously Perkin would give none.

Minutes, everyone was herded back into the wagons. Another several hours of hard riding brought them to the manor at Montlier, a grand city lined with towering buildings that made Allistair feel small and out of place.

In the center of the city was a massive statue of an owl and a shrine to the house of Farrow. Obviously, the people took fierce pride in their noble line.

When the knights arrived outside the gate to the manor, Perkin announced that he was going to meet with Duke Korbyn, and that while he was gone, everyone needed to take the people into a nearby hut, a small wooden building with a thatched roof.

Allistair was able to talk to Sir Camden as the guards shoved the people in the hut. A few tried to fight against it, but the guards would beat them until they submitted.

Allistair stared in disbelief, disgust boiling in his throat, and hissed at Camden, “What the feck is going on?”

Camden glanced around nervously for a moment before whispering, “They are being sold into slavery. There are mines southwest of here that they will work at.”

Allistair opened his mouth to scream, but Camden warned, “Don’t! There is nothing we can do. If we try to stop this, we will be beaten, and they will still be slaves.”

“We have to stop it!” Allistair insisted.

“We can’t,” Camden insisted grimly. “There is so much about our kingdom you don’t know, but you cannot fight the system. It’s broken.”

“Perhaps it’s working just as they want,” Allistair shot back. “Open your eyes. The king and royal houses want us to swallow fairy tales about how noble they are while they commit atrocities. It’s working perfectly – for them. Knight Avants are idolized, but I wish I’d never become one.”

“You can’t get out,” Camden warned, the longing in his voice showing he wanted to. “If you try, you will be flogged or killed. They cannot have people who know too much running around loose. Just get along, so you don’t die.”

Allistair watched helplessly as the captives were forced into the hut, every instinct screaming at him to save them, but there was nothing he could do... Wait... Was there?

Allistair was not small, standing a little over six feet tall and was a champion and knight. Perhaps he could do something.

He hid right outside the hut, near the door, behind a bush, with his heart pounding, and his breath sounding as if it was screaming to everyone about what he was about to do. Hopefully, he wouldn’t be caught. Yet, the risk was high even with the sun setting and darkness creeping in.

From his position, he could hear Perkin and Duke Korbyn when they walked up by the door. Duke Korbyn was more intimidating than facing a chimeric beast. Korbyn was obviously part crevan, as the bear ears and build were obvious. He was part giant too, as he had almost six inches on Allistair. Allistair would bet on him

over a bear even without a weapon. Korbyn and Perkin stepped inside for a minute. Allistair could hear an argument with the captives and a hard strike followed by an agonizing scream. If only he could run in and save the poor victim, but all that would do is get him captured and flogged.

He listened to the strikes, tensing each time, feeling as if he'd failed the prisoners. Yet, he had to wait. If he did, he might be able to later unlock the door and let the people out.

There wasn't much time to. As soon as Perkin and Korbyn came out, Korbyn stated, "They will do. Our deal is complete. Let me know when you can get more."

"That's not hard," Perkin gloated. "Capturing the Rhys makes them more angered and more willing to give us control in the name of protection. The collien are easy to come by. We have men who capture them from the mountains north of us. They are natural born miners."

"Indeed," Korbyn agreed. "You sell impressive goods."

Goods? … Goods? … Allistair had heard right. The people had just been called goods. Again, he wanted to draw his sword and fight Korbyn and Perkin right there – but he couldn't. Perhaps some of the guards would fight with him, but not likely many would. Camden definitely was too feckless to stand up.

Allistair waited until Korbyn offered to have everyone come to the great hall for an ale before making a move. He waited for everyone but the guards who were guarding the hut to leave and then jumped out of the bushes. He put one guard in a choke hold and knocked him out pretty quickly. The other screamed for help,

jeopadizing Allistair's chance of success. Allistair kicked him over and then kicked him in the temple, trying to knock out, not kill; but he may have killed the man. There was no time to check. He immediately went over to the door. It was barred, so he lifted the bar only to find there was a lock too. He had no idea how to pick the lock, so he kicked the door in. He felt his knee pop as he did and sharp pain shot up his leg. He breathed in to help himself focus and tried to ignore the pain, a skill he was too familiar with as a champion and knight.

He quickly stepped into the crowded hut. There was a dead man on the floor, obviously beaten by Perkin and Korbyn. Allistair's heart raced faster than a fox on a hunt. He should have come sooner. Maybe he could have saved the man. No, he couldn't beat himself up. He had to focus.

"Go!" he ordered. "Leave while you can. Guards will come soon."

The people all ran out of the hut with guards already coming after them, hopinv they could make it to freedom.

Allistair couldn't fight the dozen guards, so he did the only thing he could think to – he grabbed a torch from the hut and started lighting anything he could on fire. No one was in the hut, so he lit its roof. Then he lit a few barrels that were near it and a wagon.

As he'd hoped, several of the guards did stop to put out the fires. Still, the people would be pursued. Had he really saved them, or were they going to be killed by the guards?

Allistair spotted the next wave of guards charging in and bolted west – the exact opposite direction the prisoners had fled – determined to lead the guards the

wrong way. It had to work. He had to do whatever it took to buy them time.

He was a fast runner, but a sharp pain burned through his knee, and his head spun wildly, threatening to black him out. Still, he kept going.

The second he judged he was out of the guard's sight, he climbed a tree, as high as he could, and tried not to make a sound so the guards would lose his trail and give up.

The guards didn't give up easily. They combed the woods very thoroughly, torches sweeping the undergrowth while minutes stretched like hours as Allistair clung silently to the upper branches.

Once the footsteps and voices of the guards finally faded, Allistair climbed down from the tree, only to realize he had no idea where to rum. All the Knight Avants were at the Jagged Dagger Tavern drinking. Definitely, he wasn't going there. Yet, where else could he go? He he had to put distance between himself and the manor fast, before Perkin had him tracked down, so he ran southeast until he found a tavern. The sign above it read, "The Hidden Pearl." Whether it was safe or trap, he opened the door and stepped in.

Entirely focused on hiding, not even noticing anything about the tavern, he walked inconspicuously across the room and asked a serving wench there if there was a room for rent. She took his money and handed him a key. He glanced down the hall, handed her extra money, and whispered, "That is for ale, and for silence. If anyone asks, I'm not here."

She looked at the coins he'd put in her hand and eagerly agreed, "You aren't here."

He went back to the room, and sat on the bed with his face in his hands, wanting the drink. What had he done? Where should he go? He couldn't go back to the Knight Avants. Yet, that meant that he couldn't go back to Lina either. What a terrifying thought! She was not like any girl he'd ever met. There was something so intriguing, so amazing about her. Yet, he felt like he had to try to help the captives. He couldn't let them be sold into slavery. He rubbed his face with his hand. Had he helped them? Did they make it to safety? Perhaps they'd been caught, or worse, killed. There was no way for him to know if they had successfully escaped.

His thoughts were broken when the serving wench slipped into the room with a mug of ale. She held it out to him and asked, "Do you need anything else?"

He forced a tight grin. "Information. Until you find any, keep the ale coming." He handed her more coins, sank onto the edge of the bed, and started drinking. He needed the drink. How many mugs was it going to take for him to drown out the noise in his head and feel nothing at all? After all, he had no idea what to do next. He couldn't set foot back to Roifort, and the Avants would hunt for him in Chesterfield. He'd made some powerful enemies, and his reckless plan may have failed completely. How would he ever know if the captives safely escaped or ended up in chains anyway?

He sat alone in the dim room, staring at the floorboards until the door creaked open once more. The serving wench set a fresh mug on the table beside him and slipped back out – leaving Allistair in the quiet with nothing left for company but the ale, his aching leg, and the heavy silence of being a hunted man.

Chapter 12: A Gati, A Sprite, and A Beautiful Faunen

The next morning, Allistair woke up in one piece, relieved that the serving wench hadn't sold him out. He stepped into the main room, painfully aware that he was wearing the clothing of the Knight Avants. If only he'd run away with a cloak.

He claimed a table in the dimmest corner or the room, trying to figure out his next move. The same serving wench brought him some bread. He'd been a little spoiled as a Knight Avant, where breakfast meant bread, cheese, and fresh fruit. Still, he was grateful to have anything. In Chesterfield, he often went straight to working as a carpenter and didn't eat until noon, unless it was a tournament day. He always ate before competing.

He was breaking the bread when a cloaked figure suddenly appeared beside his table, his skin and hair color changing from the drab color of the walls to blond

hair and green eyes. He swept his cloak back to show a forest green tunic, black trousers, and a dagger on his belt.

Allistair startled, one hand dropping to the hilt of his sword. Clearly, the man was a sprite – and part crevan too, judging by his pointed fox ears. Could he be a royal spy or a lesser knight? Allistair narrowed his. “What do you want?”

“To help you,” the man replied, his tone smooth and confident. “I am Phillipe. I belong to the Freedom Faction. We can protect you and train you in the ways of the faction.”

Allistair instinctively leaned back from him, sizing him up with a skeptical scowl. “What exactly are the ways of the faction?”

“We fight for freedom,” Phillipe answered.

Allistair gave a slow, dry nod. “Freedom is a noble cause.”

Phillipe leaned over him. “We believe in protecting ordinary people and keeping them safe, and we believe we should be free to do just that.”

Allistair stared at him for a long beat. Those sounded like decent enough goals, but could he actually trust Phillipe? The Knight Avants sounded noble too, and they were rotten to the core.

“What do you have to lose?” Phillipe pressed. “You need our protection. You have made a deadly enemy of the Knight Avants.”

Allistair tapped his fingers on the table for a moment as he considered what Phillipe had said. “So why stick you neck out for me? You know I’m a problem and will

bring trouble."

"Because you know the inside of the castle," Phillipe admitted. "We do have some spies, but as a Knight Avant, you've been able to go through doors our spies can't."

"Interesting," Allistair noted, one brow raising. "What exactly do you want to do if I hand over the layout of the keep and knight's tower?"

"Purge it of corruption," Phillipe answered proudly.

"No," Allistair immediately refused. "That's feckin' murder. I'm not interested. I don't know that you and I will have the same definition of corruption, or the same methods of 'purging.' I think I'm better off on my own."

"Nonsense," Phillipe corrected. "You are going to be hunted down and butchered. You need our protection."

That was, unfortunately, true. Allistair reconsidered and finally conceded, "I'll see what you have to offer, but I'm not giving you a single detail about Knight Avants or the keep until I see for myself that we actually have the same goals."

"Agreed," Phillipe conceded, nodding once. "Let's ride."

Allistair finished his bread and headed out with Phillipe, who had two saddled horses waiting by the hitching post.

The ride to the faction's complex was daunting. The fortress was massive – an ancient stronghold carved straight into the base of the mountain. It had stood abandoned for years before the faction claimed it.

They rode up a steep road cut through the stone the complex was built on and up to the main gate, which was

thick and iron banded. Phillipe whispered a code word to the guard at the gate, not that he needed to, as they greeted him by name the second he rode up. Phillipe led Allistair into the courtyard inside the gate where stable hands stepped forward to take their horses.

“Follow me,” Phillipe instructed.

Allistair followed Phillipe up a staircase to a large room where two dozen men were practicing fighting.

“How many men are in the faction?” Allistair asked.

“About fifty,” Phillipe answered. “Plus a few cooks and workers. Now, do not talk, come with me.”

Phillipe led him through the fighting practice and up to a man who was obviously a gati due to his long legs and six fingers. Phillipe pointed to the gati. “This is Raphael. He is our leader.”

Raphael stepped over and looked up and down at Allistair, obviously sizing him up, before requesting, “Let’s see what you can do.”

Allistair eyed him warily. “What do you mean?”

Raphael ignored, instructing a man, “Both of you fight.”

“Wrestle,” Phillipe informed Allistair.

Allistair walked over to the man and held out his hand. “I’m Allistair. You are?”

“Devil’s Blight,” the man answered, looking at Allistairs hand but not shaking it.. “You can call me Blight. Let’s fight.”

Both men took their shirts off. Allistair had several more markings. The sign of the Knight Avants was on his

chest, meat hooks were over his shoulders, and a rope went loosely around his neck and down his back.

Yet, his markings weren't important. His opponent was. He stared at Blight, unsure what the rules were or how he was supposed to know when to start. It didn't take long to figure out, as Blight charged immediately in. It was also easy to see it was not going to be wrestling, but a full out brawl. Allistair had done that before. He preferred wrestling or grappling, but he'd been in plenty of fist fights. Champions were supposed to fight by cleaner rules, but they didn't always.

As they fought, Blight grew more desperate and vicious, as if something horrible awaited him if he lost. That made no sense. After all, the fight was supposed to just be a sparring test for Raphael to see what Allistair could do.

Despite that, the fight still felt deadly serious, and Allistair couldn't shake the gut feeling that more was riding on the outcome than he knew. What really was the faction?

He didn't get a chance to dwell on it, as Blight whipped into a vicious move known as the "slicer," forcing Allistair to twist hard out of the hold and scramble back before Blight broke his arm.

The grapple raged on until Allistair managed to wrench Blight face down on the floor, locking his arm into a tight arm bar.

Allistair looked up at Raphael and announced, "I won!"

"Not yet," Raphael corrected coldly. "Break his arm."

Allistair froze, looking as stunned as if he'd just opened a cupboard and seen a rattlesnake. "No," he refused flatly. "That's feckin' barbaric. I have nothing against him and nothing to prove."

"I disagree," Raphael replied. "You have everything to prove to us. You need our protection." He stepped closer and ordered, "Get up."

Allistair pushed himself to his feet. He didn't compliment Blight on a good fight as champion manners would require. After all, Blight had fought dirty, and Allistair was feeling the pain from the cheap shots.

Still, Allistair's stomach churned when Raphael ordered two men to drag Blight out and administer ten lashes with a whip for his loss.

Raphael then calmly stepped up to Allistair. "You are a very remarkably skilled fighter. I am impressed. Now, I wish to hear your story."

Allistair was surprised that instead of being instructed to practice with the other men that he was brought up to a room that wasn't like the others he'd seen in the complex. It was large, not to the size of a great hall, but still quite large. There were women dancing in it and a large table of food.

Raphael placed his hand on Allistair's shoulder. "We do well enough here to afford some luxuries. You will very quickly learn the rules to the faction. If you do as you are told and your missions are successful, you can have wine and women. If not, you will be punished."

Punished, likely whipped… That sounded less like a brotherhood and more like another cage. Allistair swept his eyes around the chamber. "What are you actually fighting for? I'm not convinced it's freedom, or you

would have freed the slaves yourselves."

"We intend to," Raphael explained. "That would take more numbers than we currently have. We have saved a few. That is where some of these women come from. Now, let's not talk business. Have some wine."

A beautiful lady came over with a bottle of wine for him. A tinkling sound rang as she walked. Allistair noticed the cord with bells on the end. That was the sign of a lady of ill repute. He looked around. All but one of the women in the room wore them.

"It appears that you feckin' drag the women from one form of slavery straight into another," Allistair snarled, disgust thick in his voice.

Raphael merely chuckled, waving a dismissive hand. "Just have a drink and enjoy."

The lady with the wine introduced herself as Marie. She had long brown hair and green eyes that had a hint of sadness to them despite her smiling face. Her coloring and her small wings showed she was obviously a faunen, likely not entirely full faunen, as her wings were too small to fly.

"Come," she offered. "Let me make you happy."

She took him over to where he could sit on a cushioned couch and gave him wine. As he drank it, she, and other ladies, danced for him.

Allistair drank the wine. It was strong, stronger than any wine or ale he'd ever had, but it went down deceptively smooth, so sweetly intoxicating that he ended up draining the entire bottle.

After enough wine, he danced with the girls, sang at the top of his voice, and did many things that he couldn't

remember the next morning.

The next morning, he woke to find himself in a room. Marie was there. She had rye bread and cheese on a plate that she handed to him. She also gave him a large mug of something.

“I don’t need more ale right now,” Allistair complained. “I have a headache that could kill a beast.”

“This will help,” Marie assured him, again handing him the mug. “It’s not ale. It’s an herbal drink to help with the hangover. You’ll still have a headache, but you need to be able to function today.”

Allistair timidly reached for the mug. “What will I be doing?”

“Mostly training,” Marie answered. “Raphael will teach you to be an incredible fighter. You’re already amazing, but you will learn even more. There are few as skilled as the faction.”

Allistair took a sip of the drink. Definitely, it wasn’t alcohol. “What’s the faction really fighting for?”

Marie shrugged. “Does it matter? I’m here because they saved me from slavery in the mines. You’re here because you are hiding from the Knight Avants. If either of us leaves, we will likely die.”

Allistair held the mug with both hands, thinking instead of drinking. “Why would you die? No one should be after you.”

“You never know,” Marie answered. “Korbyn’s men do not like slaves leaving. Even if I ran far away, I wouldn’t be safe. Raphael could very well sell my location out to Korbyn.”

Allistair swirled the liquid around in his mug. “How would he know?”

Marie glanced around, then whispered, “Raphael can find anyone. He is an excellent tracker and has informants everywhere. You cannot escape. If you upset him, he’ll have you assassinated.”

Allistair rubbed his forehead and concluded, “We can’t leave. That’s not good.”

“But you do need to get to practice,” Marie informed him. “You made a very good impression yesterday beating Blight. I suggest you keep impressing Raphael. If he respects you, your life will be much better.”

Allistair guzzled the drink and stood up. He swayed for a moment, but then followed Marie out of the room.

He was greeted by Phillipe and led to the same room they were fighting in the day before.

Allistair really would rather have gone back to sleep, but Raphael decided to personally train him.

Raphael was every bit the fighter everyone said he was, but Allistair knew enough unusual moves to really make a good showing for himself, even with his massive hang over.

The day of training was long and tiring. Allistair expected Raphael to question him afterward, trying to get him to draw a map of a keep, but Rafael didn’t. Instead, he took him to the harem of maidens again and gave him plenty of wine.

Allistair looked at the bottle of wine. He didn’t just want it; he needed it. So much had happened. He left the Knight Avants with his dream of being one crushed and came to the faction, knowing better than to trust them.

Yet, it was the situation he was in. There was nothing he could really do about it. The wine would be his escape. It was strong wine, and it would take little for him to forget everything. That's what he wanted – to forget, to feel nothing.

He chugged the wine and watched the women dance. Marie was quite beautiful. She seemed to have a good attitude about her situation, but still seemed to have so much pain inside. Perhaps he could help her – No, he couldn't. He could do nothing. He looked at the bottle of wine. It was empty. He held it up and called out, "I want more."

A wry smile crossed Raphael's face as he motioned for a maiden to bring another bottle. "Of course. Drink all you want." He then elbowed Phillipe, who was beside him, leaned toward him, and whispered, "Soon, he'll be entirely under our control."

Chapter 13: Misery, Mistakes, and a Spiked Whip

Weeks dragged on, and Allistair found himself trapped in the same grind day after day. He spent his mornings training to fight, ran missions for Raphael by afternoon, and drown his evenings in wine and women, always trying to escape into a bottle.

The toll showed plainly on him. One side of his face now bore the dark mark of a skull with horns. He wasn't sure if it was a symbol of the corruption he'd walked into with the Knight Avants or if it was showing a real demon taking root inside him.

Trapped. That was the only word for how he felt. Yet, what could he do? He refused to go back to the Knight Avants, but had nowhere else to turn. Maybe he could go home, but he'd feel like such a failure going back. How could he let his family see the wreck he'd become?

He had a mission waiting, so there was no time to dwell on it. The faction regularly robbed from those they decided deserved it and redistributed the money. It was feckin' despicable. Allistair knew every bit of it was wrong, but he justified going along by convincing himself that he didn't have a choice. Perhaps he didn't. After all, the wine was strong and viciously addicting. He needed it.

The mission he was to do that day was risky. He was to help a group into the castle courtyard and rescue one of theirs who was supposed to be executed.

It wasn't really that hard to get in the castle courtyard even though there were guards all around. That part wouldn't be any trouble.

Allistair pulled his hood lower over his face. He really wanted a drink, but it was early in the day and there was no chance to get one.

He swept his eyes inconspicuously around the courtyard. Something felt off. If an execution was about to take place, the square should have been busier. After all, executions weren't so common that people ignored them. Allistair paused, thinking back. Maybe they were. There had been two in the short time he was a Knight Avant, and each time several men were executed. Allistair assumed they were the cutthroats he'd been told they were. Looking back, he wasn't so sure. If only he'd woken up to what was really going on earlier – not that he was doing any better since he left. The faction was every bit as corrupt, just wearing a different mask. They preached about fighting for freedom and wiping out criminals, but what they deemed crimes and what Allistair did rarely lined up.

He looked around warily, scanning the courtyard until Phillipe leaned over to him and requested, “Show us into the keep. Where would they be keeping a prisoner?”

“He won’t be in the keep,” Allistair corrected. “The dungeons are under the guard tower. I don’t think we can break him out of there. It’s too well-guarded, and I’ll be recognized.”

“It’s better than having to try to rescue him during the execution,” Phillipe argued. “How about leading us to the king so we can negotiate for his freedom?”

Allistair eyed him suspiciously. “No… Feckin’ no!”

Phillipe sneered back, “You will regret this.” He then pulled out a whistle and blew it.

Almost instantly, Sir Guilhem, Sir Perkin, and a dozen Knight Avants were surrounding Allistair A dozen guards stood behind them.

Every muscle in Allistair’s body tensed. “What’s going on?”

“We made a deal,” Phillipe explained. “We want our man. They want you.”

Allistair glanced around. He was surrounded and helpless, trapped like a fox in a snare, without an ally anywhere. He raised his hands to chest level.

“Are you surrendering or getting ready to fight?” Phillipe asked.

“He’s surrendering,” Perkin gloated. “He knows better to even try to draw his sword.”

Allistair did know better. He also knew he couldn’t fight all of them with any weapon. “I surrender,” Allistair conceded.

Perkin was far too smug as he ordered the knights to grab Allistair. As soon as they did, he had his men turn over the Freedom Faction prisoner to Phillipe.

Allistair held his head high as he shot back at Phillipe, “I knew you were a thieving fox and a yaldson, but I seem to have overrated your character.”

“I am a clever fox,” Phillipe quipped back, a smug grin curling his lip. “You cannot doubt my intelligence.”

Allistair let out a dry chuckle. “I never accused you of being intelligent. Honestly, I’m am glad to be free of you.”

“Quiet!” Perkin barked. “Allistair, you are coming back to the Knight Avants. I have orders to bring you back. You have disgraced us, sullied the sacred name of the Avants, and will be taught a lesson.”

Cold dread struck through Allistair like a blade, and he tried to hide the shiver running down his spine and his heart racing as if it were trying to get out of his chest and run away.

The second Phillipe and his men left, Perkin and the other knights seized Allistair and dragged him toward the dungeon.

The main room of the dungeon, where guards took their shifts guarding the prisoners, was very nice, even though the Knight Avants were not over the prisoners; Jareth was. The ceiling was high and there was fancy arch-work around the cells. A large table and padded chairs afforded the guards luxury while on duty.

Yet, the cells were wretched. Allistair was thrown into a cramped cell. The ceiling was high enough for him to stand, yet the cell itself measured barely six feet by

eight, offering nothing inside but damp, barren stone walls and scattered rat droppings.

Allistair sat on the filthy floor defeated, his hands tied and nothing to do but anticipate whatever torture they were planning for him. That wasn't a dreadful thought. He'd either be tortured and killed or left there to rot. Either way, he would die a painful death. How had his dream of being a Knight Avant turned into such a nightmare?

He hadn't been in the cell long when Perkin came personally with Jareth to see him.

"So, this is the prisoner you told me of," Jareth hissed. "He is quite the troublemaker."

Perkin glared at Allistair. "He is. I would like to recondition him so he learns his duty."

Jareth stepped up to the cell bars and sized up Allistair. "You really thought you could hide with the Freedom Faction? You are a fool. Now, you are not only guilty of sabotaging an Avant and deserting them, but you're a common thief. I'll personally see to it that the king sentences you to death."

Allistair throat tightened, fighting back tears. What had he gotten himself into? He'd failed at everything. His lifelong dream of being a Knight Avant had imploded into a miserable failure. He'd joined the Freedom Faction against his better judgment, and let their spiked wine hook him. He'd committed crimes he despised. He'd set out to be the hero, only to wind up rotting in a dungeon waiting to die. "If you are going to kill me, do it quickly," he pleaded.

Perkin let out a harsh bark of laughter and mocked, "I am not letting you off that easily. I have never liked

you. You never deserved to wear the Avant crest. It was only because of that fool, Sir Xavier, that you did. You are a disgrace. You marched in here spouting your shiny ideals and wanting to play the hero. It was pathetic." He stepped closer and hissed through the bars, "You are pathetic!"

"I've done nothing to you," Allistair shot back, gripping the cold iron bars.

Perkin glared daggers at him. "You have. You have defied my orders, refused to fall in line, and sang of corruption, exposing secrets, and calling my tales lies."

A dawning of understanding suddenly struck. Apparently, Allistair had damaged Perkin's reputation, which meant far more to him than any morals.

"If you want a better reputation, stop feckin' lying to people," Allistair rebuked. "Stop being part of the intrigues."

"Silence!" Perkin yelled, clutching a bar of the cell with such might that Allistair thought it might bend.

Perkin then turned to Jareth. "I want to recondition him myself. Let me beat him."

"Approved," Jareth agreed, as if Perkin had just asked to pass the salt. "I do enjoy torturing prisoners, but this one is yours." He then nodded to Perkin, added, "Don't kill him yet," and walked out of the room.

Perkin smiled victoriously, gloating in his victory over Allistair, and had him escorted to the torture chamber.

The torture chamber was only a room over, but Allistair was bound and surrounded by guards as he was taken to it. The few steps were laden with a foreboding

aura of the pain he knew was to come.

Perkin had Allistair's shirt removed and his hands cuffed in irons that hung from chains anchored in the ceiling. Then Perkin stepped up and hissed in Allistair's face, "You mocked us! Now, I get to punish you for it. I will make you loyal to me and the Avants. I will break you so you believe anything you are told by me or Guilhem without question."

Allistair wasn't sure what Perkin was going to do, as he hadn't seen prisoners punished before, but he'd heard rumors of horrible tortures. There were stories of people being buried in the ground up to their neck and their faces smeared in honey so the bugs and rodents would eat them. There were rumors of tortures that were even worse. Honestly, Allistair felt some relief when Perkin picked up a whip. Unfortunately, it wasn't a normal whip, but a barbed cat-o-nine, which was sure to leave him bloody.

Allistair thought himself brave, as he'd fought men and beasts, but never had he felt so helpless. "Give me a fighting chance," he challenged. "You and me, Perkin. It is a coward who has to tie a man to beat him. Let me go and fight me fairly."

Perkin laughed, a mocking, haunting laugh. "You are in no position to make demands. I don't need to fight. I have won. Now, I get my prize, seeing you suffer!"

How could anyone get pleasure from seeing someone else in pain? Allistair didn't know, as he never delighted in someone else's suffering.

"Beg for mercy!" Perkin sneered.

"Feckin' Never," Allistair refused. "You don't even understand the word."

That was a bold thing to say in his position, and it sent Perkin into a rage, so he immediately threw the first strike.

Allistair braced himself for the hit, but as the barbs sliced across his back, there was nothing he could do to stop the burning pain that cried out to him as a testimony of the cruelty of the knights he once admired. Yet, he couldn't let himself scream. He couldn't give Perkin the satisfaction, so he clenched his lips shut and held his breath for a second to keep the scream from coming.

The next strike came, and that time, it was harder to not cry out. The searing burn and sharp pain was followed by the feeling of blood running down his back. Perkin was hitting hard and cutting deep for only two strikes.

The next strike came. Still, Allistair refused to cry out; but by the tenth strike, he could no longer keep the agonizing cries suppressed. He screamed in agony, and Perkin laughed a mocking, sadistic laugh which made Allistair tense so the next strike hurt more.

Soon the dungeon echoed with the cries of Allistair as the whip struck across his back with a biting sting and the barbs ripping through his flesh time after time.

When Alllistair was weak enough that he could not hold his head up, Perkin walked over and mocked, "Not as strong as you thought? Now you see where your place is." He then kicked the sides of both of Allistair's knees. An audible crunch indicated they likely were broken. Allistair's howl of agony drowned everything out, so even he could not hear the noise of the punches that followed.

Perkin laughed. "You aren't so bold now, are you?"

as he pulled his sword and cut Allistair's ear half off.

Blood ran down Allistair's face, and he passed out.

He didn't wake up until the middle of the night, when he felt something. He'd been dreaming of a beautiful maiden, and was surprised that when he woke up, there was one over him.

"Lina!" he exclaimed with eyes wide.

"Shh!" she warned. "Come."

How could he come? He'd been tortured. His back was in agony, and his knees were broken.

"You'll make it," Lina assured him.

Allistair tried to stand up. Pain shot up from his knees but he could stand. "How?" he asked. "How am I standing?"

"My healing magic," Lina explained. "I did what I could for you. You're going to hurt, but I used my healing stone." She blushed as she admitted, "And I kissed you. That can heal better from an elf."

Allistair's eyes went wide with shock. "What?"

"Just get over it," Lina retorted. "We need to go."

Allistair glanced around, looking for guards. "How did you get in, and why aren't we being stopped?"

"Come," Lina ordered. "Answers later."

As they left, Lina explained that she had bribed the guards. At least, she gave them strong wine and they passed out.

She led Allistair out of the dungeon and carefully out toward the main gate.

“We’ll never get through,” Allistair warned.

“Yes, we will,” Lina assured him confidently. “I have this planned. Follow me.”

She led him through the gatehouse. The guard on duty did not even look at them as they went behind him.

“How?” Allistair asked as they headed out the door to the outside of the wall.

“That guard is named Claude,” Lina explained. “He is sympathetic, and is willing to let you and me escape, but he wants to be able to say he did not see us. Now, into the wagon.”

She pointed to her wagon. They both hurried over and hopped in.

It was late as they rode off, and the sound of the wagon rang through the air, cutting the silence and calling to all about their escape.

“Where to?” Allistair asked, suddenly stopping the horse. “I have no place to go.”

“Yes you do,” Lina corrected. “You’re going home.”

Allistair clasped his hands and fought back his emotions as he confessed, “I can’t. I can’t go without the faction’s ale without feeling horrible. I have betrayed everyone who cares about me, everything my parents taught, and I left you behind.”

Lina put her hand on his arm and smiled encouragingly. “Your parents will still love you. They will help.” Her eyes lit up as she assured him, “I will help you too.”

Allistair gazed into her eyes. “But I bring trouble. I’ve made some bad enemies.”

“True,” Lina agreed quite happily, “but you still need to go home. It’s our best option.”

Allistair flicked the reigns and started the horses moving again. Perhaps going home was his best option, but how could he face his family? He’d failed at everything. He gripped the reins tightly with trembling hands.

Lina placed her han on his arm. “Nervous?”

“Partly,” Allistair admitted, gripping the reins. “I’m shaking from going without the faction’s wine, and I’m terrified of the trouble I’m about to bring to my own family.” He shook his head/ “I don’t even know what I’m going to do once we reach Chesterfield. I’m in no shape to fight as a champion. Perhaps I can go back to carpentry.” He straightened up and decided, “I have no idea what comes next, but I’ve hit rock bottom, and the only way left is up. It’s time to clear my head, stay off the bottle, and make some changes.”

Chapter 14: Recovery, a Goal, and a Suitor

The next few months were really hard. Allistair's parents welcomed him home with outpouring love. They found Raissa and had her heal him. She was happy to do it, for a price, of course. Still, his knees would likely get injured again easily. Fortunately, when healing his ear, he hadn't lost any hearing.

The hardest part of the recovery was trying to break the addiction. A faunen couldn't heal that. The faction's wine was incredibly strong, so Allistair couldn't sleep without alcohol. His hands shook. He sweated almost constantly, and he had horrible headaches for a while. There were times he hallucinated and scared everyone around him, but his parents, Hartley, and Lina were great supports.

His mother offered to get his sister, Millie, to come help, as she was good at making healing elixirs, but Allistair refused. After all, Millie was married and she and her husband, Hayden, lived in Tamur, which was

overseen by Duke Berenger, who was a gati. Allistair knew more than he wished to of Berenger. Duke Berenger spoke a great deal of fairness and equality, but he taxed the people with incredibly high taxes and gave them freedom only as long as they used it how he wanted them to. Allistair saw that wasn't true freedom, which was one of the reasons he no longer lived there. He had grown up in Tamur, but he and his parents had moved to Chesterfield where they had more opportunities. His sister stayed in Tamur because of her husband and job. Still, he visited often. As an outsider, it was easier to see the feigned freedom and how Berrenger was controlling his people.

For the first time in Allistair's life, he wasn't sure he wanted his sister to see him, not as he was. Withdrawal was ugly, and he'd done some things with the Knight Avants and faction that he really regretted.

"Beating yourself up over the past won't help. You have to take all the rocks they threw at you and build your castle." Lina urged softly as they sat out on a quilt under a sprawling, starry. A soft breeze rustled the grass, and Lina gave a slight shiver.

Allistair slipped off his jerkin and handed it to her to wear. "You look good in my clothes," he teased as she put it on.

She laughed and punched him lightly in the arm. "What? Are you implying something?"

"Oh, you can take a joke," he grinned. Then his expression sobered, the warmth fading from his eyes. "I don't know what my next move should be. I thought the Knight Avants were everything their reputation claimed, but they aren't. Nothing is. The knights are feckin'

corrupt. King Didier is feckless and corrupt. Duke Korbyn is evil and corrupt. The Freedom Faction is barbaric and corrupt. Is there a single place in this kingdome that isn't corrupt? At this point, I think all the houses are rotten."

"I don't know they all are," Lina countered, tucking her kneed under his jerkin. "I heard a great deal while living in the castle. I was allowed access to travel some, as minstrels need to hear news. Kind Didier isn't corrupt. He's just weak. He knows what is good for the kingdom, and he wants it, but he doesn't have the backbone to stand up to the other houses. From what I understand, that's how the elves are. They see themselves as peacemakers, but what they're really doing is caving in to get along so nobody starts a fight."

"That's not peace," Allistair snapped. "That's feckin' servitude. Didier may mean well, but refusing to stand up for what is right is its own form of corruption. Evil wins every time good men do nothing."

"True," Lina agreed. "Didier is weak, entirely feckless. Ormondo is from Montlier, and they want power for their house. The end justifies the means to them, so they will do anything to get what they want."

Allistair rolled his eyes. "Definitely, they will use slaves." He sighed. "I don't know if the slaves I freed made it to freedom or were captured and killed. I hope I helped."

Lina patted him on the shoulder. "You tried to. Stop beating yourself up over the past. If it was the wrong choice, God knows you were trying to help, and he forgives. Personally, I think you assume that they made it to safety unless you have reason not to."

Allistair shook his head. “Didier is corrupt. His counselors are corrupt. The Knight Avants are corrupt, so is the faction. We know the corruption in Tamur. You say the elves are weak. Is there anyplace that isn’t feckin’ corrupt besides Chesterfield? It’s not corrupt yet, but with all the extra taxes, it’s headed to control by Roifort. At least I lowered the extra tax.”

Lina placed her hand on his arm. “Maybe I shouldn’t tell you this, but your parents told me that a month later, Sir Elliot announced an even higher extra tax, so they ended up paying the extra money anyway.”

Allistair threw his hands in the air. “And the people just feckin’ paid it? How do we get people to wake up to what’s going on around them? I don’t think anyplace is going to be safe soon.”

Lina gestured with her hand for a moment as if thinking. “Perhaps Bellemar would be. They are rather isolationists, so people don’t know much about them, but I’ve visited there before. It’s where I learned to be a minstrel.”

“Really?” Allistair asked. A slight smile rising on his face. “It’s good to have you open up, even if it’s only a little, about your past.”

Lina’s expression turned comtemplative, as if watching a memory. “Bellemar is mostly populated by faunen, sprites, and a race called courtites. The house of Garnier is made up of a mix of faunen and courtites. Courtities are short, love to eat, and love to garden. They are simple people, but very hard-working. They appreciate minstrels, as they work hard during the day and really enjoy entertainment at night.”

“They were the fourth house, the one that gave up

being involved in politics long ago," Allistair clarified.

Lina nodded. "They did give up competing, I told you courtites are small. They are under five feet tall. They aren't fighters, so they can't win the crown."

"Maybe you are part courtite," Allistair teased, ducking back as if expecting to be hit. "That would explain why you are so short."

She slapped him lightly on the arm and huffed, "I'm five foot four. That's not that short." Then her expression softened, her eyes locking onto his, and raw sincerity warmed her voice. "I may look innocent and weak, but I don't need to be afraid. I have the best protector in the kingdom."

"I wouldn't bet on that," Allistair muttered, his gaze dropping to the dirt. "I failed you, Lina. I left you behind. You had to save me. You deserve much better than me. Truth is, if you can find a different protector, you will be much safer. I have powerful enemies."

"I don't want a different protector," Lina shot back. "I want you. Like it or not, you're my partner. I'm impressed that you fought your way through a nightmare and come out strong. You've stayed off the bottle for two whole months now, and I know you will keep it that way."

"I'm never touching a drop again," Allistair swore, meeting her eyes.

"Then neither am I," Lina replied with a fierce little nod. "We're in this together."

Allistair threw his hands in the air. "I'm not even sure what we're in. What's our next step? I can't really go back to being a champion. My knees will get injured too

easily. I have lost all desire to be a knight. I tried to go off on my own, but ended up with the faction, and trust me, they are feckin' corrupt. I have no idea what to do now."

"That's not hard," Lina replied. "You're my partner. I think we go around and sing."

"Sing," Allistair muttered as he thought about it. He waved his finger for a moment in thought. "That's half of an idea. How about if we sing of the corruption and try to wake people up?"

Lina gasped. "Wake them up to do what? Are you trying to start a rebellion?"

"No," Allistair answered. "I don't want bloodshed. I want people to open their eyes to the corruption around them. I want the truth out. Then I want to get some conversation going. No one sees themselves as the feckin' bad guy while horrible atrocities are done. First, we find all the truth. Then we get it out to everyone. That's our first step. I think my first song will be called 'Dear Knights.' Perhaps I can reach some of them. If not, maybe I can expose them." He jumped up to get started.

Lina bounced excitedly. "This sounds like a solid plan. I think you are back to your lovable self."

Allistair stopped dead in his tracks and turned around. "Lovable? Are you implying that…" He paused, reached out his hand, pulled her to her feet, and gazed into her warm brown eyes. Her hair that day was a soft peach, and her smile completely disarmed him. "You are so gorgeous, so full of life, so fun, and still sharper than anyone I know. I couldn't stop thinking of you while we were apart."

"I thought of you too," Lina admitted, a soft, genuine smile lighting up her face.

Her eyes sparkled as he gazed into them. He slipped his strong arms around her. He'd held plenty of maidens before, but Lina was nothing like any of them. She was extraordinary. Perhaps one day he'd write a song for her, but no words could do her justice.

He drew in closer, hands resting at her waist, and whispered, "You're incredible, Lina."

Neither could deny the pull between them, a quiet spark neither had ever felt before.

Allistair lifted hand to Lina's cheek and brushed her hair back from her eyes, revealing the delicate flowers with thorns winding along her temples. They were striking. Everything about her captivated him, and not just her appearance. She was sweet, yet spunky; so feminine, yet so fiercely strong. He'd been through the fire, but with her in his arms, he felt ready to take on the entire world.

"You're amazing," he whispered again before returning his hand to her waist. Feeling her pressed against him sent a jolt of excitement through his chest, yet nothing compared to the surge of joy as he leaned in and kissed her. Her kiss was unhurried, sweet, and completely genuine.

After the kiss, he kept her tucked close in his arms. "I will do everything I can to protect you," he promised. "Lina, I know I'm not good enough for you, but I want to be your suitor. May I court you?"

"I'd love that," she replied, her dark eyes shining. "I think we make a great couple."

Allistair raised his eyebrows in warning. "Even knowing I have enemies? I've already made plenty, and singing to expose the corruption will make more."

“I know,” Lina stated simply. She gave a small, confident shrug. “I’m with you through the good and the bad.”

“I’m afraid I might bring you more bad than good,” Allistair warned.

She smiled playfully, sliding her hand along his arm. “I’ll take my chances. I trust you.”

Allistair shook his head and looked away. “I’m not sure that’s wise. I’ve made a pretty big mess of my life.”

She laid her palm on his cheek and gently turned his face back so she could look straight into his eyes. “I have faith in you. And honestly, I think your song ‘Dear Knights’ is a brilliant idea.”

A slow grin spread across his face. “I’ll get to writing it.”

“Right this?” Lina asked, one brow arching.

Allistair let out a low chuckle. “I have something way more important to do first.” Once again, their eyes met, and he leaned in to kiss her. For one quiet heartbeat, all the troubles and danger faded away. All Allistair could feel was hope. Lina was nothing like any lady he’d ever met before, and he was fortunate enough to now be her suitor. Heaven was smiling on him.

After the kiss, he caressed her cheek gently and confessed, “Lina, seriously, I’m not good enough for you, but I hope I can keep you fooled, because if I’m not mistaken, I think this might be love.”

Chapter 15: A Song, an Argument, and a Spicy Lime

A week later, Allistair and Lina found themselves at the Spicy Lime Hub, an inn southeast of Roifort. It was very near Fletcher's Field where tournaments took place, so everyone was familiar with it.

The Spicy Lime Hub also had a wide variety of visitors, as it was located in the center of the kingdom, so many people stopped there when traveling.

The place was full that night, and Allistair was a little nervous as he and Lina stood up.

They had written a song for the occasion, but instead of the lute, Lina was playing the drums. They had decided to just go with a beat and have Allistair speak the words to a rhythm instead of singing a melody, so people would listen to the words not just the music.

Allistair sang:

"It's so easy for knights to just do what they
want, to forget what they stand for and who
they should be.
They complain that life's hard while they drink
and they wench, and they don't ever think of
the small guys like me.
But while coopers, and potters, and tinsmiths
need skill, all the knights have no concept
those skills are so hard.
I had dreams that I'd grow up to be a strong
knight, but they're shallow, so I'd rather live
as a bard.
They crushed all my dreams, all my faith, all my
hope, 'cause they look at their job as no
more than a game.
Still I wanted some heroes who I could respect,
so I looked up to them, but they only want
fame."

Lina picked up her lute and played as Allistair took over on the drums and they both sang:

"No, no, no. I'm disappointed.
No, no, now I'm full of shame.
No, no, no. I've been bamboozled.
No, no, now I know your game."

Lina went back to the drums as Allistair again spoke to the rhythm:

"So I don't want to hear of the knights and their
tales. They're all lies that they tell you to
make them look good.

They are fronts to control and to kill who they want. They've no backbones to stand up and do what they should.
Then the king and the dukes say the kingdom's at peace, when they know there are slaves and oppression around.
They work with the thugs, and the thieves, and the scum, and then act like they're servants just serving the crown.
If you listen to truth, and you think with your head, then you'll see through the fraud, the deception, and lies.
They're conditioning you to just give what you're told. Their demands should be met with 'I will not comply.'"

Again Lina played the lute and Allistair the drums as they both sang:

"No, no, no. I'm disappointed.
No, no, now I'm full of shame.
No, no, no. I've been bamboozled.
No, no, now I know your game."

They finished the song to a very mixed reaction. A few people cheered for them. Most clapped politely. Many stared at them, stunned at what had been said, and a few became very angry.

"You don't know what you're talking about!" an intimidating rhys called out. "The king is there to take care of us."

"No," Allistair countered. "The king and the Knight Avants are supposed to protect us from war and

criminals. We are supposed to take care of ourselves."

The man and several other rhys stormed over to Allistair. "You just want to hold us down! You don't understand the life of the rhys. Our people go missing, and without the king and knights, we would be slaughtered by beasts. Beasts swarm around Varoux. We need more tax coin than we get to make up for it. The king gives us some, but we need more. We don't even get representation among the counselors. Jareth needs to be made a counselor."

Jareth? Allistair knew him all too well, as the man ran the dungeon. Allistair didn't know much about him beyond the fact that he was cold and cruel to prisoners. He didn't know much about the beasts either. He'd fought a few, but had no idea where they came from. They never ventured near Chesterfield.

"Chesterfield doesn't get representation from a counselor either," Allistair pointed out. "I'm not saying that is right. I'm not saying the system is good. I think the system makes everyone feel like a victim, whether mokos, rhys, or sprite, it hates us all. At least what I've seen from the inside, our system is broken. "

"We need to fix the system!" the man insisted. "We need to give them the power to give us more."

Did he even hear himself? Allistair shook his head. "Maybe the system isn't broken and needs to be fixed," he countered. "Perhaps it's the people propping it up."

"We need more!" the man roared. "The rhys are held down. Our city is falling apart. We don't have the privileges of the people in Roifort or big cities."

"Then grab some tools and fix up your city," Allistair shot back. "Or move to another one and get a job."

“It’s not that easy for a rhys,” the man complained. “What job would I get?”

Allistair shrugged. “What skills do you have?”

“I don’t have the privilege of being born with skills,” the man argued.

“Most people aren’t,” Allistair countered. “I worked hard to learn carpentry and to learn to fight as a champion. If you don’t have a skill, I suggest that you start as an apprentice somewhere. That’s how I learned.”

“I shouldn’t have to work!” the man fumed. “You have no idea what you’re talking about.”

Lina stepped over and suggested, “Let’s dance, Allistair. Don’t argue with a fool. He’s not going to see reason. Arguing with fools merely pulls people down to their level where they can beat you with experience.”

Allistair turned to her. “Would you like to dance?”

There was a lute player playing music, so they started dancing. Allistair wasn’t a dancer, but it did give him an excuse to hold Lina in his arms.

They danced throughout the night, and between dances many people talked to them. His song had sparked something. In some, it sparked anger. In others, it sparked thought. Several people talked to him about what he knew, how he knew it, and what they should do, although most of them did not have the strength to stand against corruption.

A crevan man stormed over to him and accused, “You’re trying to raise a rebellion!”

“No,” Allistair corrected, standing boldly against him. “I’m not trying to move anyone to violence. That’s

honestly what our corrupt leaders want. I'm just trying to get people to see the truth."

"And do what?" the man hissed in his face.

"Those who see the corruption are less likely to support it," Allistair explained calmly. "I want people to not be fools and blindly follow those who are not acting in their interest. We need to hold those in charge accountable for their actions."

"I think you're trying to cause a revolt!" the man again accused.

Allistair shook his head. The man wasn't going to listen.

"Let's dance again," Lina suggested.

Dancing with Lina was more fun than arguing with fools, so Allistair again took her to dance.

Dancing with Lina was pure magic, and Allistair was surprised how much more he enjoyed the evening, completely clear-headed. He'd always figured that ale was the secret to a good night, but he didn't miss it at all. Lina's energy was infectious, full of spark and laughter, making the night delightful without a single drop of ale. Best of all, he'd actually remember every moment and have no regrets and no hangover.

There was plenty to savor about the night, mostly Lina. Spinning her across the floor felt dream-like. She made him feel like a hero again, like he could stand up against the world.

Everything was going smoothly until Sir Elliot barged through the door. What was he doing at the Spicy Lime?

“Allistair,” Elliot hissed as he strode up to him. “You seem to be causing problems.”

“I’ve done nothing wrong,” Allistair replied coolly. “A minstrel is free to sing any song he pleases. You can’t arrest me for singing.”

Elliot stepped closer and threatened, “I can’t right now, but watch out. I’m watching you, and you’ve made some very dangerous enemies.”

“Tell me something I feckin’ don’t know,” Allistair retorted without a hint of his fear showing. “Now, I’m going to go dance with my lady.” He took Lina’s hand to go dance.

As they stepped away, Elliot slammed his palm on a table and fumed, “You are going to regret this!”

Chapter 16: A Raid, A New Guild, and A Lifeless Halo

Allistair and Lina drove their wagon through the northeast section of Tamur. They had both lived there before, so they were familiar with the city, but not that part of it. Duke Berenger of the House of Vinet ruled over the city. He was very controlling, and insisted that everyone in Tamur was to be equal. Of course that didn't apply to those of the House of Vinet. They had many luxuries and privileges others didn't.

Allistair and Lina rode into a small village on the edge of the city. It looked as if there had just been a battle there. Wagons were turned over, cottages were burned, and faunen were healing injured people.

As soon as Allistair and Lena stopped and hopped out of their wagon, Allistair stopped the first person he could, a lady with a small child, and asked, "What happened? Can we help?"

“I don’t know,” she answered. “You should talk to him.” She pointed to a man who was working and giving orders to others. “I doubt you can do anything unless you have food or can help rebuild.” She noticed the lute. “I doubt tales or music will really do much.”

“You might be surprised,” Lina corrected. “There is great power in music. If any of you are to have hope, music will help.”

“I can help rebuild,” Allistair added. “I am not only a minstrel. I’m a carpenter.”

The lady smiled, and Allistair and Lina went to talk to the leader of the village. He was a bearded gati, named Samuel, and was more than happy to have extra help. He put Allistair straight to work.

As Allistair worked to rebuild a torn down fence, Samuel noted, “You are quite good. You must love your craft.”

“No,” Allistair admitted. “Swinging hammers in the hot sun or freezing cold is not something I really enjoy, but it’s paid bills and helped make me who I am. Now, will you explain what happened here?”

“Of course,” Samuel agreed. “Duke Berenger sent his knights to raid our village. They claimed that Tamur was attacked by several beasts and that they destroyed farms and food and the people needed our food. We keep supplies in case times get rough. They stole our food, insisting that it wasn’t right for us to horde it, and that everyone needed food as badly as we did, so they were taking it for them.”

Allistair fought to suppress the anger boiling inside him. After all, Samuel hadn’t done anything wrong. He drew a slow breath to steady his tone before replying,

“That’s feckin’ robbery! I’m sure you would give to those in need, but that should always be by your choice, not taken by force. Do you have enough to feed your village?”

“I don’t know,” Samuel answered through gritted teeth. “Why can’t the people of Temur see what is going on?”

Allistair hit a nail in the fence he was rebuilding with a hammer. “Because they’ve been told feckin’ lies all their lives.” He paused as he nailed another nail in. “And because people are stupid! They believe what they want, and everyone being equal or taking from those who have and giving to those who don’t sounds good, not realizing how hard the people worked for what they have. They choose not to think about the implementation until they are the victims.”

Samuel looked around at the fence. “We’ll have to go cut down some trees. There’s too much fire damage to save some of this.”

“I’m on it,” Allistair assured him. “Perhaps I can take the frustration out on the tree.” They both picked up their saws and headed toward woods.

As they worked, Lina helped try to salvage food and hunt for edible plants. When she had breaks, she sang for everyone. The music definitely helped everyone pick their spirits up, the peaceful melody making the air feel fresh and bringing hope.

She sang:

> “I know you did your best. You did nothing to blame.
> They don’t know all the work you put in. It’s a shame.

They think it’s merely luck. They think it’s such a breeze.
They don’t know how you’ve worked for all the stuff they seize.
Yes, everyone has problems, and life can be quite hard.
I sure know it’s not easy for me as a bard.
We should all see each other with love and true respect.
Let’s listen, not be quick to judge, and then object.”

A lady stopped her when she sang that and asked, “How are we supposed to love people who treat us so rotten? They just stole everything from us. Duke Berenger doesn’t care about us. King Didier doesn’t care about us.”

“I know,” Lina agreed. “I’m not saying what they are doing is right. Yet we need to forgive and love. We need to choose to be happy. We have to forgive others for our own sakes, not theirs. Allistair and I are taking big risks to try to inform people of the truth. I’m sure there is more truth that we don’t know. Still, I’ve chosen to be happy. That’s a choice. Standing up for what is right is too. Allistair and I aren’t trying to raise a rebellion. Our enemies would love a bloody revolt. That would give them an excuse to use force to eliminate those who oppose them. We just need to make our voices heard and not stand down. We need to not be afraid to stand for what is good and true.”

The lady patted her arm. “You are brave.”

“I can be,” Lina chirped with a happy smile. “I have a great protector and partner.”

The lady smiled knowingly. “So, you and him?”

Lina blushed, a huge smile brightening her face. “Yes, he’s my suitor.”

Allistair happened to walk up right at that moment. He was sweating from the hard work. Lina came to hug him, but he stepped back and warned, “I’m really sweaty.”

“I don’t care,” she assured him, as she threw her arms around him.

He wasn’t dumb enough to turn down the hug. He kept her in his arms and responded with the romantic statement, “I hear there’s food. I’m starving.”

Lina laughed, not surprised at all, so soon they were eating together. The meal was simple, as most of the villagers’ food had been stolen, but everyone was happy to have food at all.

Allistair looked around and sighed.

Lina placed her hand on his arm. “You’re worried. You want to help everyone and can’t.”

“True,” Allistair confirmed. He pointed to the newest markings on his face. Where he had a skull with horns on one side of his face, the other had a face with a halo. He really wasn’t sure what that meant. The face seemed lifeless, and the halo seemed out of place. “What is this? Is it a bad omen?”

Lina studied it for a moment. “I don’t think so. I think it shows that you are going up against demons but you aren’t going to let them corrupt you. You are going to keep speaking the truth and standing for what is right.”

Allistair rolled his eyes. “Most people don’t want to

hear the truth."

Lina smiled encouraginly. "But these people do. That's good. They need some push to stand up for what's right, but they are good people who see what's going on."

"True," Allistair condeded, picking up his mug of honeyed water. "They know, but they don't feel they can do anything."

"They can't really," Lina pointed out. "I think we need to see what is going on around all the kingdom. We need to get the word out, and we need to build a group of people who will be a support group for each other, like family. That way, everyone can feel safer standing up for what's right."

"Good idea," Allistair agreed. "What should we call our group of followers?"

"I don't know," Lina answered, "but I'm sure a name will come to us."

It did come to them later that night. Everyone went back to work until it was too dark to continue. Then, the innkeeper announced that the invaders hadn't taken all his casks of ale, and began passing mugs out to everyone.

The people drank, trying to forget the horrors of the knights' invasion.

Allistair and Lina abstained, but understood why the others wanted the escape.

After two hours, the innkeeper approached Allistair, "You said you wanted a name for all of us who believe in you and support what you stand for. How about the Hangover Guild? After all, I'm sure most of this lot will have a hangover tomorrow."

“Allistair and I don’t drink,” Lina pointed out.

“I like it,” Allistair countered, his voice rising so the nearby crowd could hear. “It’s not about ale or hangovers. It’s about friends and camaraderie. It fits that we share a moment of joy together tonight, knoing tomorrow we must face the harsh realities of our kingdom, just as everyone here must face the hangover tomorrow. From this night forward, all who stand with us belong to the Hangover Guild.”

For the rest of this book, please email Renee at darkhairedhalfling@yahoo.com